



P A R I S

A Humanized Walking Tour

Orsay

A Walking Tour of the Musée d'Orsay

32 tracks · word-for-word narration script

The train station that became the museum of the modern eye

“Notre devoir est d’aller au fond des choses.”

— Our duty is to go to the bottom of things —

Émile Zola · defending Manet · 1866

V4 · Humanized pacing edition · English narration

A Walking Tour

Orsay

The Musée d'Orsay · Paris · 31 tracks · approximately 2 hours 35 minutes

A word-for-word narration script for a complete walking tour of the Musée d'Orsay. Thirty-one tracks across three phases of the building — the central nave on level zero, the sculpture terraces and Van Gogh suite on level two, and the Impressionist gallery on level five — ending in the Café Campana behind the second great clock face. The tour covers sixty-six years of European art, from the academic painting of the 1840s through the founding moments of modern art at the turn of the twentieth century. The script can be used as a printed walking guide or as the source text for an audio production.

Phase 1 · Level 0 · Central nave

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 - T31 · Café Campana — the closing chord
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Track 01

Welcome and Navigation Guide

Before you go in · How to use this tour

4 min

◆ Stop & Look

Anywhere convenient before you reach the museum doors — on the metro to Solférino, walking along the Seine, or already at the Esplanade Valéry Giscard d'Estaing in front of the building. Take a moment with this welcome track before you cross into the entrance queue. The first content track begins inside, under the glass roof.

Welcome to Paris. And welcome to the Musée d'Orsay — the train station that became the museum of the modern eye.

What you're about to walk through is the world's most concentrated collection of art from 1848 to 1914. Sixty-six years. The period when European painting tore itself apart and rebuilt itself into something that could carry the modern century. Courbet, Manet, Whistler, Monet, Renoir, Van Gogh, Cézanne, Gauguin, Seurat. All of them. Under one glass roof.

The cover of this script carries a line from Émile Zola, written in 1866 when he was defending Manet against critics who wanted to destroy him. *Notre devoir est d'aller au fond des choses*. Our duty is to go to the bottom of things. That's the spirit of the whole museum. The painters in this building stopped painting what was expected of them and started painting what was actually in front of them — in a railway station, in a Paris café, on a harvest field, on a body that wasn't a goddess. Whatever the subject, the impulse was the same. Go to the bottom of things.

What you're visiting in 2026-2028

Important first thing to know: the museum is in the middle of a major renovation that runs from 2026 to 2028. The chief architect leading the work is Marie-Suzanne de Ponthaud, chief architect of historic monuments. The forecourt is being rebuilt — the original 1980s polychrome floor by the French artist Guy de Rougemont, in Vosges granite and coloured marble, is being restored to its first finish. The glass canopy over the building is being restored. The entry and exit have been separated, after studies of visitor flow concluded the old single-point system wasn't working. The famous animal sculptures that used to greet visitors on the esplanade — the rhinoceros by Jacquemart, the elephant by Frémiet, the horse by Rouillard — have been temporarily removed for restoration. They're on long-term loan at the Jardin des Plantes on the other side of the

Seine, attached to the Muséum national d'Histoire naturelle, until they come back to the esplanade in 2028. If you came here expecting to see the rhinoceros, you'll find him there. The museum stays open throughout all of this work. What you're seeing is a building in the middle of being cared for.

Getting in

The easiest way is metro line 12 to Solférino, then a five-minute walk to the Seine. RER C stops directly at Musée d'Orsay. Two entrances under the renovation: Entrance 1 (the Seine quay side) for timed-ticket holders, Entrance 2 (the forecourt) for priority visitors. Booking online beats showing up cold every day of the week. The queue at the door without a timed ticket can swallow an hour or more in summer.

Hours

Tuesday through Sunday, 9:30 in the morning to 6:00 in the evening. Closed Monday. Late opening Thursday evenings until 9:45 p.m., which is the quietest time to see the museum if your schedule allows it. Last entry one hour before closing. The rooms start clearing thirty minutes before closing. Closed May 1st and December 25th.

How long this tour takes

Thirty-two tracks. About two and a half hours of narration. Add the walking, the standing in front of paintings, the time you spend just looking — you're looking at three to four hours minimum. Most people end up staying longer than they planned. Bring water. Wear shoes that can handle marble floors. There are benches in almost every room — use them.

How the tour is shaped

Three phases, by floor. Phase one on the ground floor — the old train platform level — covers the building itself and the painters who broke open the nineteenth century: Couture, Millet, Courbet, Manet, Whistler, Toulouse-Lautrec, and the Symbolists. Phase two on level two covers the sculpture terraces, the Pavillon Amont, the new Nazi-restitution gallery, Van Gogh, and Gauguin. Phase three on level five is the Impressionist heart of the museum — Monet, Renoir, Pissarro, Degas, Cézanne, Seurat — ending in the Café Campana behind the second great clock face.

When you're ready, walk into the museum, present your ticket, and step through into the central nave. Press play on Track Two once you're standing under the glass roof and you can see the great clock at the far end.

Track 02

Laloux's Station

Under the glass roof · The building that nearly wasn't a museum

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

You're inside the museum, in the central nave. The huge vaulted glass ceiling is above you. Sculptures line the central walkway. Walk to a position where you can see down the full length of the nave — from the entrance side to the far wall with the great clock. Then start the track.

Look up. Take a moment with the ceiling before you take a moment with anything else.

What you're standing in is not a building that was designed as a museum. It's a building that was designed as a train station, rescued from demolition in the 1970s, and converted into a museum in the 1980s. The conversion is one of the best decisions Paris has made in the last fifty years.

Victor Laloux's problem

The architect was Victor Laloux. The year was 1898. The Compagnie du Chemin de fer de Paris à Orléans, the railway company for the southwest of France, needed a new terminal station in the centre of Paris in time for the 1900 World's Fair. The site they chose was directly across the Seine from the Louvre and the Tuileries gardens — prime real estate, surrounded by classical stone buildings and the Beaux-Arts establishment of the Third Republic.

Laloux had a problem. A train station in 1900 meant steam, smoke, soot, iron, and the kind of industrial architecture that had been raised in Paris around the Gare du Nord and the Gare Saint-Lazare. He could not put a soot-stained iron warehouse directly opposite the Louvre. The neighbourhood would not allow it, the Beaux-Arts academy would not allow it, the state would not allow it.

So Laloux did something clever. He built two buildings in one. On the outside, a Beaux-Arts palace — pale limestone, classical ornament, the kind of facade that belonged on the Seine quay across from the Louvre. On the inside, the most advanced train station of its era — a single vast glass-and-iron vault, 138 metres long, 40 metres wide, electrified from the start. The first electrified urban rail terminal in Europe. No steam to stain the stone. No smoke to choke the platforms.

Look up again. That barrel vault above you is the original 1900 structure. The glass roof is a listed historic monument — it's being restored as we speak, as part of the current renovation. The decorative coffered rosettes you see in the ceiling are plaster, masking the iron. The iron weighs about twelve thousand tons. The whole canopy is essentially

an Eiffel-Tower-scale industrial structure dressed up as a ballroom ceiling.

Forty years as a working station

The station opened on the 14th of July 1900. For forty years it was a working terminal — trains from the southwest of France arriving at platforms right where you're standing. In 1939 the platforms became too short for the longer electric trains then coming into service, and most of the long-distance traffic was diverted to Austerlitz. The building drifted out of railway use.

What happened to it next is a strange list. During the Second World War, it was a mailing centre for parcels sent to French prisoners of war in Germany. After the Liberation, it was a reception centre for returning French prisoners and deportees. In 1962, Orson Welles filmed parts of *The Trial* here, using the empty station hall as the warped Kafkaesque court. By the 1970s, the building was a candidate for demolition. A luxury hotel chain wanted to knock it down and put up a glass tower.

Saved

It was Georges Pompidou — the president of France from 1969 to 1974 — who first proposed turning the station into a museum. Pompidou died before the plan was realised, but Valéry Giscard d'Estaing, the next president, kept the project alive. François Mitterrand, the next president after that, inaugurated the museum on the 9th of December 1986. Three French presidents touched this project. The Italian architect Gae Aulenti designed the interior — the stone terraces, the sculpture nave, the way the light falls. That intervention is also now a listed heritage element. When the museum talks about “blending heritage and modernity” in the current renovation, what they mean is preserving Laloux's 1900 bones *and* Aulenti's 1986 conversion.

Now look down the nave toward the far wall. You can see the shape of the old train platforms in the stepped stone terraces either side of the central walkway. The sculptures are placed along what used to be the track bed. The far end of the nave leads up to the great clock. We'll get there at the start of Half B. First — the first painting on this tour, a twenty-five-foot-wide canvas hanging here on level zero that taught a whole generation of French painters what to rebel against. Walk to the central wall of the nave, find Thomas Couture's *Romans of the Decadence*, and stand about ten metres back. Track Three begins there.

Track 03

Couture's *Romans of the Decadence*

Central nave, level 0 · The peak of academic painting

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Walk back into the central nave on level zero (the ground floor). Find the very large painting on the central wall — about seven metres wide, a debauched Roman banquet scene with marble columns, sprawled bodies, and tall white statues looking down on them. This is Thomas Couture's *Romans of the Decadence*. Stand about ten metres back so you can see the whole canvas.

This painting is enormous. Stand back. Let your eye take it in as one composition before you start picking out the details.

What you're looking at is Thomas Couture's *The Romans of the Decadence*, painted between 1844 and 1847. It is one of the few paintings in this museum that everyone in 1847 Paris agreed was a masterpiece. It won the gold medal at the 1847 Salon. The French state bought it immediately. Théophile Gautier called it the most important painting of the decade. Couture became one of the most famous painters in Europe overnight.

What it shows

The scene is a debauched Roman feast, set inside a grand classical hall. In the centre, exhausted aristocrats are draped across couches in various states of undress, surrounded by spilled wine cups and discarded flower wreaths. The party is ending. The bodies are slumped. The faces are blank or asleep or staring at nothing.

Now look at the columns. Between each column stands a tall white statue of one of the founding heroes of the Roman Republic — the ancestors of these very Romans. The statues are upright, noble, austere. They look down at the orgy below them with cold stone faces. The contrast is the whole point: the great ancestors stand sober and unmoving while the descendants collapse in their shadow.

On the far right, two figures stand apart from the party — soberly dressed philosophers, looking at the scene with what Couture called "deep sadness." They're the moral observers. They're also, secretly, the painter's view of his own century. Couture was using ancient Rome as a coded warning about the France of King Louis-Philippe — the wealthy bourgeoisie of the 1840s, getting fat on industrial money while the republic's founding ideals were forgotten. The 1848 revolution — which overthrew Louis-Philippe — broke out within a year of this painting being unveiled.

Why this painting matters here

This is the painting that the Impressionists rebelled against. Look at how it's made: every figure is carefully posed, every fold of drapery is meticulously rendered, every brushstroke is polished invisible. The lighting is theatrical. The composition is symmetrical, classical, balanced. The subject is borrowed from history. The technique is the technique you learned at the École des Beaux-Arts — the state academy where French painters were trained, judged, and ranked.

Couture was the model. Hundreds of younger painters tried to paint like him. One of those younger painters, briefly, was Édouard Manet — who studied in Couture's studio from 1850 to 1856 and then walked out, because he couldn't stand the academic training another year. We'll see Manet's response to this kind of painting later in this tour, on the same floor, in two canvases that broke the Academy open.

I want to be careful here. The standard story of nineteenth-century French art tells you that Couture and his Academy were the villains and the Impressionists were the heroes who saved painting from them. That story is too simple. Couture was not a fraud. He was a brilliant technician working inside a tradition that genuinely valued moral seriousness, narrative depth, and craftsmanship. Many of the painters who later became Impressionists trained inside that same tradition and continued to submit to the official Salon for years. The break didn't happen overnight. What changed between Couture and Monet was not that one was good and the other was bad. It was what painters thought painting *was for*. We'll watch that change happen, painting by painting, all the way through this tour.

Walk down the Lille side of the nave — the inland side, away from the Seine. Find the gallery dedicated to academic painters of the 1850s and 60s, and beyond it the Symbolist room — the *Salle du Bord de l'eau*. Track Four takes us into that world, briefly, before we move into Realism and Impressionism.

Track 04

Ingres and the Symbolists

Level 0, Lille side · The Source and the Salle du Bord de l'eau

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Walk to the Lille side of the central nave on level zero — the side opposite the Seine. Look for the academic painting room (Ingres, Cabanel, Bouguereau) and the adjoining Symbolist room called the *Salle du Bord de l'eau*. We're going to look at two works in two rooms — Ingres' *The Source* and Gustave Moreau's *L'Apparition*.

Two rooms, two paintings. We're going to move fast through both, because they're both side-trips from the main story of this museum — but they're both essential context for understanding what the Impressionists thought they were fighting against, and what was happening parallel to Impressionism that was not the same thing at all.

Ingres' *The Source*

First, find the standing nude with a water jar tipped over her shoulder. This is *La Source* — *The Source* — by Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres. He started it in 1820 and finished it in 1856. Thirty-six years on one painting. He was eighty-six years old when it was unveiled.

Ingres was the most powerful painter in France for most of the 19th century. He led the Neoclassical movement — the tradition that believed painting should imitate Greek and Roman marble: cold, smooth, idealised, drawn before it's coloured. Look at the surface of *The Source*. The skin is impossibly polished. The contour line is razor-sharp. The whole figure looks like she's carved out of porcelain. Ingres said that drawing was "the probity of art" — by which he meant the honesty, the spine, the discipline. Colour was secondary. The Impressionists, half a century later, would reverse this completely. Colour would be everything, and the contour line would dissolve into light. But while Ingres was alive, his view was the orthodoxy.

Look at her face. It's expressionless. That blankness is deliberate — Ingres wasn't painting a person, he was painting the *idea* of a nymph, the platonic form of a young water spirit. The Impressionists would walk away from this kind of idealisation. They wanted painted faces to be people. *The Source* is the wall they were pushing off from.

The Symbolist room

Now walk into the adjoining room — the *Salle du Bord de l'eau*, the Riverside Room, dedicated to the Symbolist movement. You'll see darker walls, smaller pictures, a different atmosphere. The two key works in here are Gustave Moreau's *L'Apparition* and Odilon Redon's *Les Yeux clos* — *The Apparition* and *Closed Eyes*.

Find Moreau's *L'Apparition* first — the watercolour with Salome and a floating head. The biblical story is brief: Salome dances for King Herod at his birthday feast, and as a reward she asks for the head of John the Baptist on a platter. Moreau paints the moment

the head appears — a glowing severed head, haloed in light, floating in mid-air above the dance floor. Salome stands frozen with her arm raised, jewelled and barely dressed, transfixed by the vision.

This watercolour was unveiled at the 1876 Salon. It became instantly famous and inspired a generation of late-19th-century writers and painters — most famously Joris-Karl Huysmans, who wrote a long ecstatic passage about this painting in his 1884 novel *À Rebours* (*Against Nature*), and Oscar Wilde, who saw it in Paris in 1884 and went home and wrote his play *Salomé* based on it. Moreau was running parallel to Impressionism, not in opposition to it. While Monet was painting light on water, Moreau was painting dreams, severed heads, femmes fatales, and biblical visions. Symbolism is the other half of the late 19th century — the side that fed surrealism and decadence and Freudian dream-imagery.

Look at Redon's *Les Yeux clos* next to it — a single face with the eyes closed, floating in a misty grey-blue field. Redon spent the first half of his career making dark charcoal drawings of nightmares, then in his sixties switched suddenly to brilliant colour. Both are here at Orsay. *Closed Eyes* is from 1890. The closed eyes are not death; they're inwardness. The painter is asking you to look at someone who is looking at something inside themselves that you cannot see.

Walk back toward the Seine side of the nave. We're going to Jean-François Millet next, into the Barbizon room. The pivot from Ingres and Moreau to Millet is the pivot from the idealised body and the dream to the dirty body and the harvest field.

Track 05

Millet's *The Gleaners*

Level 0, Seine side · Three women in a wheat field

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Cross to the Seine side of the central nave on level zero. Find the Barbizon school room — the painters who left Paris to paint rural life. The painting you're looking for is Jean-François Millet's *The Gleaners*: three peasant women bent in a wheat field at the end of harvest, with golden haystacks behind them.

Three women. A wheat field. Late afternoon light. Look at the painting before you read the wall text.

This is *Des Glaneuses* — *The Gleaners* — painted by Jean-François Millet in 1857 and shown at the Salon that year. It is now one of the most famous paintings in this museum. It was, when it was first shown, one of the most hated paintings of the year.

What gleaning was

Look at what the women are actually doing. The wheat harvest is over — you can see the haystacks rising behind them, the wagon loaded with grain, the supervisor on horseback in the distance. The three women in the foreground are bent double, picking up the leftover stalks that the harvesters dropped on the ground. This was called gleaning — a legal right under French law that let the poorest people in a village walk a harvested field after the landowner was done, and keep whatever scraps they could find. A handful of broken stalks at the end of a day of bent-back work.

Look at their hands. Coarse. Sunburned. Look at their clothes — rough fabric, patched, faded. Look at their faces — you can't really see them, because their heads are bent. They're not individuals here. They're a class. The rural poor of mid-19th-century France, doing the work that fed Paris.

Why this painting scandalised people

Millet did something that the Paris art establishment found deeply uncomfortable. He took the lowest agricultural workers in France and he painted them at the scale, with the dignity, with the compositional weight that academic painters reserved for biblical scenes, royal portraits, and ancient heroes. The three figures are arranged like a Greek frieze. Their bent bodies form a slow rhythm across the canvas. The light is the warm, gold-soaked light of late-day rural France — light Millet had been studying for years from his cottage in the village of Barbizon. He made the gleaners *monumental*. He made looking at them feel like an act of seeing something serious.

Conservative critics in 1857 called Millet a socialist agitator. They said the painting was an indictment of French society. They pointed out the obvious contrast inside the frame — the abundance of the harvest in the background, the desperation in the foreground — and asked why anyone would want to hang such a thing on their wall.

Millet always denied that he was making a political statement. He said he was just painting the work he'd grown up watching, in his own village, by people he knew. "I was born a peasant," he wrote, "and I will die a peasant." But denying the politics didn't mean the politics weren't in the painting. By taking the scale and the seriousness of academic art and applying it to the people the academy ignored, he changed what painting could be *about*.

What he opened up

Every painter we're going to look at for the rest of this floor owes something to Millet. Courbet, in the next room, will take this even further — he'll paint a small-town funeral at the scale of a coronation. Manet, two rooms over, will paint a Parisian sex worker with the gravity of a Venus. The whole ground floor of this museum is built on the premise Millet established in 1857: ordinary modern people are a legitimate subject for serious art. You don't need a Roman emperor or a biblical hero. The woman bent over picking up stalks is enough.

Walk into the adjoining Courbet gallery. The two largest paintings in this museum are next door, both by the same man, both produced in the same five-year window. We're going to look at them in sequence. Track Six starts in front of *A Burial at Ornans*.

Track 06

Courbet's *A Burial at Ornans*

Level 0, Courbet gallery · The death of romantic painting

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Walk into the Courbet gallery on level zero. Two enormous horizontal paintings dominate the room — we'll look at both. For this track, stand in front of the funeral scene: a line of townspeople in black, a priest, an open grave, a grey winter sky over a small French town. This is *A Burial at Ornans*.

Stand back. This painting is twenty-two feet wide. It needs distance to be seen as one composition.

This is Gustave Courbet's *A Burial at Ornans*, painted between 1849 and 1850 and shown at the Salon of 1850-51. Courbet called it "the burial of Romanticism" — by which he meant the burial of the kind of operatic, theatrical, idealised painting that had dominated French art for the previous fifty years. He wasn't exaggerating. With this canvas, he killed a whole tradition. The Impressionists who followed him never had to fight that battle, because Courbet had already won it.

What's in the painting

A funeral in a small French town. The town is Ornans, in the Franche-Comté region of eastern France — Courbet's home town. The man being buried is Courbet's great-uncle, Claude-Étienne Teste. The mourners along the back are real people from Ornans — Courbet's neighbours, relatives, the local priest, the mayor, the local vineyard workers,

the women of the parish. Courbet painted them in his studio one by one, from memory and from sittings, and assembled them into this single horizontal frieze.

Look at the bottom centre of the canvas. The open grave is right there, cutting into the foreground, the dark rectangular hole inches from your feet. Courbet doesn't hide it. He doesn't put a beam of heavenly light coming down from above. He doesn't show angels carrying the soul up. The grave is just an empty hole, waiting.

Look at the dog in the right foreground. A normal village dog, sniffing the dirt. Not symbolic. Not allegorical. Just a dog at a funeral, the way dogs actually are at funerals in small towns. Look at the gravedigger kneeling beside the hole. He's waiting for the priest to finish. Look at the sky — a grey, flat, mid-afternoon sky over a chalk cliff. No drama. No weather. Just the weather you actually get in eastern France in October.

What the Salon of 1850 thought

The Salon jury argued for a long time about whether to accept this painting at all. The scale was the first problem. A canvas of this size was reserved, by tradition, for what the academy called *peinture d'histoire* — history painting. A coronation. A battle. The death of Caesar. The crucifixion. Courbet had taken twenty-two feet of canvas and put a small-town funeral on it. He had given monumental scale to an event that no one outside Ornans would have heard of.

The second problem was the people. The mourners in the back row are not idealised. The men have weathered faces, drinkers' noses, stubble. The women are stocky and middle-aged. The priest is fat. The mayor is bald. No one in the painting is beautiful in the academic sense. They're just the actual people who happen to live in Ornans, France, in 1849.

Conservative critics called it "a celebration of ugliness." One critic said Courbet had "dragged painting into the mud." Champfleury, defending Courbet, said he had "simply painted what he saw." The painting was both attacked and celebrated. But more importantly: it could not be ignored. The Academy couldn't pretend Courbet hadn't painted it. After this canvas, the question of what painting *could be about* was permanently open.

Realism

Courbet gave his approach a name. He called himself a Realist. He wrote a manifesto: "I cannot paint an angel because I have never seen one." He meant it literally. He would paint only what he could physically observe, at the scale he wanted, with the dignity he chose to give it. The Realist movement that he started would feed directly into Manet and the Impressionists, who took the same impulse — paint what you actually see, not what tradition tells you to paint — and turned it into something even more radical.

Turn around and look at the opposite wall. The other huge Courbet in this room is even more complicated. We're looking at *The Artist's Studio* next.

Track 07

Courbet's *The Artist's Studio*

Same Courbet gallery · The real allegory of seven years

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay in the same Courbet gallery on level zero. Turn to the companion painting — another huge canvas, showing Courbet himself in the centre, seated at an easel, with a naked model standing behind him and a small boy watching, surrounded by dozens of figures on either side. This is *The Artist's Studio*.

Stand back from this one too. It's nearly twenty feet wide. And it's one of the strangest paintings in the museum.

Courbet painted this in 1855 and gave it the longest title in the history of art: *The Painter's Studio: A Real Allegory Summing Up Seven Years of My Artistic and Moral Life*. "A real allegory" is a contradiction in terms — an allegory is an abstract symbolic image, the opposite of real. Courbet knew that. He was being provocative. He wanted to make a painting that was both: rooted in the actual people he knew, and at the same time a statement about what painting was.

The three parts

The composition has three parts. In the centre: Courbet himself, seated at an easel, painting a landscape of his home region. Behind him stands a naked female model with a white sheet draped over her hip and her hand on his shoulder. In front of him, a small boy in a peasant smock watches him paint.

To the left of Courbet: a crowd of common people. A poacher with his dogs. A canvas merchant. A priest. A beggar woman sitting on the floor with a child. A worker in a smock. Look at them — these are the people Courbet considered his real subject. The rural and urban poor of the France of his lifetime.

To the right of Courbet: a crowd of his Parisian friends and supporters. Charles Baudelaire — the poet, sitting at the far right reading a book. The wealthy patron Alfred Bruyas, who had been bankrolling Courbet for years. The art critic Champfleury, sitting on a stool. A couple of bohemian art lovers admiring a painting on the wall. These are

the people who understood his project.

The naked model and the boy

Now look at the central trio again. The naked model is not posing for the landscape Courbet is painting. She's just standing there, watching. Critics have been arguing about who she's supposed to represent for a hundred and seventy years. Truth? Nature? The naked reality that the painter has to look at to do his work? Courbet himself called her "the Muse" in his letters but never explained further. Whatever she is, she is there as a kind of standing permission — the right of the painter to see things directly.

The small boy in the peasant smock is even stranger. He's looking up at Courbet with absolute attention. He's not painted from any one model; he's a generic peasant child. Some critics have read him as the future viewer — the next generation of ordinary people coming to see what painting can do. Courbet painting toward his audience, with the audience already inside the painting watching him.

The 1855 rejection

Courbet submitted this canvas, along with thirteen other paintings, to the great Universal Exhibition of 1855 — the world's fair that Paris was hosting that year. The jury accepted eleven of his paintings and rejected three, including this one and *A Burial at Ornans*. Courbet was furious. He did something unprecedented. He built his own pavilion across the road from the official exhibition, paid for it himself, called it the *Pavilion of Realism*, and charged admission. He showed forty paintings in his own pavilion, with this canvas as the centrepiece.

That move — a painter exhibiting his own work outside the official jury system, charging the public to see it — is the birth of the independent modern art exhibition. Twenty years later, the Impressionists would do exactly the same thing in 1874, in a former photographer's studio in central Paris, when they organised their own exhibition outside the Salon and invented the name Impressionism. Courbet showed them how it was done. The Pavilion of Realism is the prototype.

Walk into the next gallery on the Seine side. We're going to meet the man who learned the most from Courbet — and who scandalised Paris far more spectacularly than Courbet ever did. Édouard Manet. Track Seven is in front of *Olympia*.

Track 08

Manet's *Olympia*

Level 0, Manet room · Painted 1863, shown 1865 — the scandal that changed everything

6 min

◆ Stop & Look

Walk into the Manet/Monet gallery on level zero, Seine side. Find the painting of a nude woman lying on a bed, staring directly at you, with a Black maid behind her holding a bouquet of flowers and a black cat at her feet. This is *Olympia*. Stand close enough to meet her eyes.

Stop and let her look at you for a moment before anything else. That eye contact is the painting's first weapon.

This is *Olympia*, painted by Édouard Manet in 1863. He didn't submit it to the Salon for two years. When it was finally shown, at the 1865 Salon, it produced what one contemporary called "the greatest scandal of the century" in Parisian art. The painting was hung high — above eye level, near the ceiling — partly to protect it from being attacked by visitors with walking sticks and umbrellas. Two policemen were posted in the room to keep order. Critics called the model "a female gorilla" and "the Queen of Spades stepping out of the bath." Manet went home shaken. His friend Baudelaire wrote to him: "You are only the first in the decrepitude of your art" — which sounds like an insult, but was Baudelaire's way of saying the future belonged to him.

Two dates: 1863 and 1865

I want to clear up a date confusion that runs through a lot of writing about this painting. Manet painted *Olympia* in 1863. The same year, he submitted a different painting to the Salon — *Le Déjeuner sur l'herbe*, the picnic with the naked woman, which we'll look at next. *Déjeuner* was rejected by the jury and shown at the special *Salon des Refusés* — the Salon of Rejected Works — that Napoleon III set up in 1863 for paintings the jury had thrown out. *Déjeuner* caused the first Manet scandal. Then Manet held *Olympia* in his studio for two years before showing it. The 1865 Salon is where *Olympia* exploded. Two paintings, two scandals, two years apart. People often blur them. The dates matter.

Why she was scandalous

Manet was working in a tradition. Nude women on beds, looking at the viewer, had been a subject in Western painting since the Renaissance. Titian's *Venus of Urbino*, painted in 1538, is the famous prototype — and *Olympia* is directly modelled on it. Manet had been to Florence, he had stood in front of the Titian, he had taken notes. So why did one painting (the Titian) become a Renaissance masterpiece and the other (the Manet) cause a riot in Paris?

The difference is the details. Titian's figure is a goddess: Venus, classical, mythological, set in a Renaissance interior, softly lit. Manet's figure is a contemporary woman. The black ribbon around her neck was a Parisian fashion accessory. The orchid in her hair, the gold bracelet, the satin slippers — these were the accessories of a high-class Parisian courtesan. The name "Olympia" was a known pseudonym for a sex worker in Paris in the 1860s. Her left hand isn't modestly placed — it's firmly held, in control. She isn't inviting you. She's weighing you up. The black cat at her feet, instead of the sleeping dog at Venus's feet, was the final detail. The implications didn't need to be spelled out.

Look at the maid behind her, holding the bouquet wrapped in paper. The maid was painted from a model named Laure, a Black woman living in Paris in the 1860s — Manet recorded her name in his sketchbook. Modern scholarship has rediscovered her, and Orsay itself held a major exhibition in 2019 called *Le modèle noir — The Black Model* — specifically to put Laure back into the painting's history. The flowers she's holding are a gift from a client — wrapped in paper, casual, the sort of thing that gets delivered between appointments.

What Manet was actually doing

The painting is not pornographic. It's not even particularly erotic by the standards of its century — the Salons were full of nudes far more sexually displayed than Olympia. What scandalised people was the *transparency*. Manet refused the alibi. He wouldn't pretend his nude was a goddess. He wouldn't even pretend she was beautiful in the academic sense — her skin is flat-lit, almost greenish in places, with none of the soft rounded modelling the Salon demanded. He painted her as the thing she actually was: a working Parisian woman whose body was her trade, looking directly at the wealthy man who would be the Salon's typical viewer, and pricing him in real time. The wealthy Parisian men who visited brothels at night and demanded purity in art by day found themselves looking at their own client relationship, hung on a wall, in public, framed as art.

Manet wasn't trying to start a revolution. He thought of himself as a serious painter working in the great tradition of Velázquez and Goya. He wanted Salon recognition. He wanted official acceptance. He didn't get it. What he got, instead, was a generation of younger painters — Monet, Renoir, Degas, Pissarro, Cézanne, all the people we're going to meet on level five — who looked at *Olympia* and understood that the rules were over. After 1865, you could paint anything. The painters of light who came after Manet were possible because Manet had done this first.

Look at the wall next to *Olympia*. The other great early Manet is right there — the picnic that started the trouble two years earlier. Track Eight is in front of *Le Déjeuner sur l'herbe*.

Track 09

Manet's *Le Déjeuner sur l'herbe*

Same Manet room · The picnic that broke the Salon

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Same Manet gallery. Move to the large painting on the adjacent wall — two fully dressed men sitting on grass with a naked woman, a picnic basket spilling fruit, a half-dressed woman bathing in the background. This is *Le Déjeuner sur l'herbe*.

Look at this picnic. Try to figure out what's happening before I tell you.

This is *Le Déjeuner sur l'herbe* — *Luncheon on the Grass* — painted by Édouard Manet in 1863. It is the painting that started Manet's public scandal, two years before *Olympia* finished it.

The Salon des Refusés

Manet submitted this canvas to the 1863 Salon. The jury rejected it. They rejected so many paintings that year, in fact, that the Emperor Napoleon III intervened personally. He decreed that the rejected works would be shown in a separate exhibition, in the same building, at the same time — the *Salon des Refusés*, the Salon of Rejected Works. Napoleon's intention was conciliatory — a way to defuse the artists' anger. The effect was the opposite. Crowds came to the Salon des Refusés specifically to laugh at what the jury had thrown out, and what they laughed at hardest was Manet's picnic.

What people couldn't accept

Look at the composition. Two men in fashionable Parisian suits — frock coats, beards, soft hats — sitting on the grass in what appears to be a forest clearing. Between them sits a naked woman, looking directly out at the viewer with an expression somewhere between amusement and challenge. She has kicked off her clothes — they're in a pile next to her, with the picnic basket. Behind them, half-undressed, another woman bathes in a stream.

The men are talking to each other. The woman is looking at *you*. None of them seem bothered by her nakedness. The men are gesturing as if continuing a philosophical conversation. The scene reads as a kind of relaxed afternoon at an artists' outing in the Bois de Boulogne — except the woman is naked and the men are not.

This was the offence. The Academy was perfectly comfortable with female nudity — as long as the nude was a mythological figure (Venus, Diana, a nymph) in a clearly imaginary setting. Manet refused both. The setting is a contemporary picnic. The woman is a contemporary Parisian. She has no excuse for being naked — no swan transformation, no bath of the goddess, no ancient myth. She's just a woman who has taken her clothes off in the woods with two clothed men. The scene reads, to a Parisian in 1863, as either a brothel scene transplanted outdoors, or an art-school model session pretending to be a picnic. Either way, the viewer is implicated. The viewer is the third man, the one whose place at the picnic she's waiting to fill.

The technical scandal

But the moral scandal was only half of it. The technical scandal was just as big. Look at the lighting on the woman's body. It's flat. There are no soft transitions from light to shadow — her body is lit from the front almost like a studio photograph, with the contour line of her skin standing out hard against the dark forest behind her. The Academy demanded smooth chiaroscuro, the gradual modelling of form, the polished surface that made painted skin feel three-dimensional. Manet refused that too.

Look at the woman bathing in the background. She's too big. Spatially, she's in the wrong scale for her position in the frame — she should be smaller. Manet did this deliberately. He was telling the viewer: this is a flat painted surface, not a window into a real space. The painting refuses the illusion. It says, openly, I am paint on canvas. Look at me as paint on canvas.

The Impressionists got it. Three or four years later, the younger painters — Monet, Renoir, Bazille — were already experimenting with the same idea: paintings that didn't hide that they were paintings. Surfaces of visible brushstroke. Light that came from the actual sun, not from theatrical studio spotlights. Subjects taken from the streets and parks of contemporary Paris. The visual rebellion against the Academy was already underway. Manet's *Déjeuner* was its first public manifesto.

Manet himself

One thing worth saying about Manet personally: he wasn't a bohemian. He wasn't a poor outsider. He came from a wealthy Parisian family, dressed elegantly, drank at the Café Tortoni, and wanted Salon medals like every other ambitious painter of his generation. He never thought of himself as a revolutionary. The scandals he caused embarrassed him. He kept submitting to the Salon for the rest of his life, hoping for official recognition. He got it briefly, near the end. The Legion of Honour came in 1881, two years before he died of complications from syphilis at the age of fifty-one. He never quite understood that the place his paintings had earned was bigger than the Salon — they had earned the future.

Walk back across the central nave. There's another major painting on this floor that doesn't fit the French story. It's by an American, it's the most famous portrait in this museum after *Olympia*, and it's done in pure tones of grey and black. Track Nine is *Whistler's Mother*.

Track 10

Whistler's *Arrangement in Grey and Black No. 1*

Level 0, Galerie Françoise Cachin area · The American expat icon

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Cross back to the Lille side of the central nave on level zero, or look for the Galerie Françoise Cachin area where international 19th-century painters and the Toulouse-Lautrec works are shown. Find a small-to-medium painting of an elderly woman seated in profile against a grey wall, wearing a long black dress, hands folded in her lap. This is *Whistler's Mother*.

Walk up to this painting and just stand with it for a moment. After the colour and theatre of Manet, this one asks you to slow down.

This is *Arrangement in Grey and Black No. 1*, painted by James McNeill Whistler in 1871. It is known to almost everyone in the world by another name: *Whistler's Mother*. The second title is the one Whistler hated. He didn't paint a mother. He painted, as he insisted his whole life, an arrangement of grey and black.

An American in Paris and London

Whistler was born in Massachusetts in 1834. He spent most of his career in London and Paris. He apprenticed in Paris between 1855 and 1859, knew Courbet, was a friend of Fantin-Latour and Manet, and showed work at the same 1863 Salon des Refusés where Manet's *Déjeuner* caused its scandal. Whistler's *Symphony in White, No. 1: The White Girl* hung in that same rejected exhibition and drew almost as much attention as the Manet.

By 1871 Whistler was living in Chelsea, London, at 96 Cheyne Walk. His mother, Anna McNeill Whistler, had moved over from America to live with him. The story — unverifiable but durable — is that the model he had booked for a portrait failed to show up one day, and his mother stepped in. She sat for the portrait standing at first, until her age forced her to sit. Whistler painted her in profile, in the dress she happened to be

wearing, against the studio wall.

What he was actually making

Whistler was a fanatic about painting as composition rather than painting as narrative. He gave his works titles borrowed from music — *Symphony in White*, *Nocturne in Black and Gold*, *Arrangement in Grey and Black*. The titles were a deliberate signal: don't look at this painting and ask what story it tells. Look at it and ask how it's balanced. He was moving toward what would later be called abstraction — the idea that a painting is first and foremost a flat surface with shapes and colours on it, and that the subject is secondary to the formal arrangement.

Look at how the painting is composed. A vertical strip of grey wall on the left. A horizontal grey curtain across the top. A framed etching (one of Whistler's own prints, called *Black Lion Wharf*) hanging on the wall in the upper-left quadrant. The seated figure in absolute profile, almost sculptural, occupying the lower-right two-thirds. The whole canvas is built out of horizontal and vertical lines — a grid — with the curve of her bonnet and folded hands as the only soft notes. The palette is grey, black, off-white, with a single touch of warmth on her face.

If you cover the face with your thumb, you can see what Whistler actually painted: a still-life arrangement of textures and rectangles. If you remove your thumb, the human face reasserts itself and the painting becomes something else — a portrait of an old woman, alone, formidable, somehow holding her own private thoughts. That double reading is the whole point. The arrangement and the mother are both there. Neither cancels the other.

How it got to Paris

Whistler submitted the painting to the Royal Academy in London in 1872. The Academy nearly rejected it, then accepted it under pressure but hung it badly. It was not a success in London. Whistler hated England's reception of his work and eventually pawned the painting. In 1891 the French state bought it directly from him — the first time France had ever bought a painting by a living American artist for the national collections. Whistler wrote to a friend: "To have one's own picture hanging in the Luxembourg, treated everywhere with deference and respect, is like a dream." He had been rescued from English indifference by the French state. The painting moved to the Louvre in 1925, then here in 1986.

There's a quiet political moment in this painting being where it is. America's most famous portrait, of an American mother, hangs not in any American museum but here in Paris. It went on loan to American museums twice in the twentieth century — to Chicago in 1933, to Pasadena in 2015 — but it always came home to the Musée d'Orsay. Anna

McNeill Whistler, sitting calmly on this wall, is one of the most travelled and most photographed mothers in the history of art. She has been parodied, reproduced on stamps, used in advertisements, and turned into a film prop. She has also been left alone here in Paris for most of the last thirty years, sitting quietly, waiting for visitors to slow down.

Now walk further into the Galerie Françoise Cachin. We're going to look at one of the most kinetic paintings in this museum — almost the opposite of this one in every way — Toulouse-Lautrec's *Jane Avril Dansant*.

Track 11

Toulouse-Lautrec — *Jane Avril Dansant*

Galerie Françoise Cachin · Montmartre nightlife on cardboard

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Move along the Galerie Françoise Cachin on level zero. Find the tall vertical painting on cardboard of a dancer in a yellow-and-black dress, one leg kicked out in mid-step, against a sparse background with two faintly sketched figures behind her. This is Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec's *Jane Avril Dansant*.

Look at her foot in mid-air. The kick is what Toulouse-Lautrec wanted you to see first.

This is *Jane Avril Dansant* — *Jane Avril Dancing* — painted around 1892 by Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec. The dancer is Jane Avril, one of the great stars of the Moulin Rouge in the 1890s, and one of Lautrec's closest friends. He painted her, drew her, made posters of her, and sat in cafés with her for the last decade of his life.

Who Lautrec was

Toulouse-Lautrec was a French aristocrat — his full name was Henri Marie Raymond de Toulouse-Lautrec-Monfa — born in 1864 into one of the oldest noble families in southern France. He had a genetic bone disease, made worse by two broken legs in childhood that healed badly. As an adult he stood about four feet eight inches tall, with adult-sized torso and head on child-sized legs. He moved with crutches and a cane. His family was wealthy enough that he never had to work, but his condition and his physical appearance closed off the noble military and political careers his father had wanted for him.

What he did instead was move to Paris, set up a studio in Montmartre — the bohemian hilltop district that was then on the edge of the city — and spend the next fifteen years drawing the people of the Parisian night. Cabaret singers. Cancan dancers. Brothel workers. The musicians, drinkers, prostitutes, circus performers, lesbians, and outcasts that respectable Paris pretended not to see. He drew them without sentimentality and without moralising. He drew them because they were the people he liked, and the people who liked him back.

Jane Avril

Jane Avril was born Jeanne Beaudon in 1868, in a working-class Paris neighbourhood. Her mother was a prostitute, her father an Italian aristocrat who had separated from her mother when Jane was two. She had a violent childhood, ran away repeatedly, attempted suicide as a teenager, and found her way into Paris dance halls through a circle of women who took her in. By the late 1880s she was performing at the newly opened Moulin Rouge in Montmartre. She had a particular style — thin, angular, almost mournful-looking offstage, but on stage capable of kicking her leg over her head with what one contemporary called “the incarnation of dance.” Her stage nickname was *La Mélinite* — melinite, a French military explosive.

Lautrec watched her dance dozens of times and drew her dozens more. The poster he made of her in 1893, advertising the Jardin de Paris, became one of the most famous lithographs of the century and helped invent the visual language of modern poster art. They were lifelong friends. After Lautrec’s death in 1901, Avril stayed close to his family, retired from dancing in 1905, married a print-maker, lost everything in the 1929 crash, and died alone in poverty in occupied Paris in 1943.

How the painting is made

Look at the surface. The painting is on cardboard, not canvas — you can see places in the upper-right where the brown cardboard shows through unpainted. Lautrec did this on purpose. He used the warm brown of the cardboard as one of his colours. He diluted his oil paint with turpentine until it ran almost like watercolour, brushed it on fast, and left whole areas of the support uncovered. The look is sketch-like, immediate, caught-in-the-moment — but every line is deliberate.

Look at her dress. Yellow on black, with a quick spray of ruffles around her ankle. Her foot is kicked forward, the movement caught in a single stroke. Her face is in profile, concentrated, almost grim — not the smiling cancan dancer of popular imagination, but a working professional in the middle of a routine. Behind her, in the upper right, are two faint figures — a man in a top hat and a woman in a feathered hat. The man is the English painter William Tom Warrener, a friend of Lautrec’s, watching from the side.

Why this gallery matters

This room — the Galerie Françoise Cachin — is named after the first director of the Musée d'Orsay, who was instrumental in establishing the museum's identity in the 1980s. She fought to make sure the museum showed the full range of late-19th-century art — not just Impressionism, but the Symbolists, the Nabis, the decorative arts, the foreign painters working in Paris, and artists like Lautrec who didn't fit any neat movement label. Lautrec was technically a Post-Impressionist, but he was also his own thing entirely — a painter who borrowed from Japanese prints, from photography, from Degas' framing, from caricature, and welded them into a style nobody else has ever managed to imitate.

He had a phrase he liked to repeat: "I can paint until I am forty. After forty I want to be drained." He drank heavily, lived in brothels, contracted syphilis, and was finally placed in a sanatorium by his family. He died at his mother's estate in 1901, at the age of thirty-six. He never got to forty.

Walk back out toward the central nave. We're going to take the escalators up to level two. Track Twelve begins on the upper terraces — the sculpture gallery with the Rodins, and the bridge across to the Pavillon Amont.

Track 12

The Pavillon Amont and Rodin Terrace

Level 2 · The new bridge into the Nabi decorative galleries

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Take the escalator up to level two. Walk out onto one of the upper terraces — the Seine-side terrace with the Rodin sculptures. Once you've had a moment with the Rodins, follow signs toward the Pavillon Amont — there's a newly added bridge that crosses into it. The track covers both spaces.

You're on level two now, on the upper terraces. The light is different up here — you're closer to the glass roof. Take a moment with the height before anything else.

This level is the museum's sculpture floor for the second half of the 19th century. Below you, in the central nave, are the monumental Romantic and Realist sculptures — Carpeaux, the Carpeaux *La Danse* we'll meet shortly, and a long line of academic marbles. Up here, on the terraces and in the Pavillon Amont beyond, you're in the

modern world — Rodin, his pupils, the decorative arts of Art Nouveau, and the Nabis.

Rodin on the terrace

Walk along the Rodin terrace. The Musée d'Orsay has a substantial Rodin holding even though most of his work is in the dedicated Musée Rodin a kilometre away. The Orsay Rodins include casts of *The Thinker*, *The Age of Bronze*, and the monumental *Gates of Hell*, his unfinished doorway commissioned for a museum of decorative arts that never got built. Look closely at the surfaces of his bronzes — thumbprints, tool-marks, the ridges where he pinched the clay with his fingers. Rodin left the marks of making visible. The Academy wanted bronze that looked like polished stone. Rodin wanted bronze that looked like a person had wrestled it into being. His surfaces flicker with movement even when the figures are still.

There's also a Camille Claudel in this area worth seeking out — *L'Âge mûr*, *The Mature Age*, sometimes called *Maturity*. Claudel was Rodin's student, lover, and collaborator for fifteen years. *L'Âge mûr* shows three figures: a young woman on her knees, naked, reaching out to a man being led away by an older woman with wings. Claudel never said it was autobiographical, but everyone who saw it understood. Rodin was the man, Rodin's long-term partner Rose Beuret was the older woman, and Claudel herself was the kneeling figure. Rodin used his influence to try to suppress the work. Claudel made it anyway. She was later institutionalised by her family at the age of forty-eight and spent the last thirty years of her life in a psychiatric hospital. *L'Âge mûr* is one of the most direct emotional sculptures of the century.

The new bridge to the Pavillon Amont

Now find the bridge across to the Pavillon Amont. This bridge is one of the most recent architectural additions to the museum — added during a major reorganisation around 2011-2012 that expanded the upper-level gallery space by about four hundred square metres. The Pavillon Amont is the pavilion at the upstream end of the old station — “amont” is French for “upstream”. The Pavillon Aval (“downstream”) is at the other end.

Once you're across the bridge, you're in the Pavillon Amont decorative arts section. The space holds the museum's collection of modern decorative pieces from 1905 to 1914 — large Art Nouveau room settings, furniture, glass, ceramics — and at the centre of it, the great *Nabi decorative works*: large mural-scale panels by Pierre Bonnard, Édouard Vuillard, Maurice Denis, and Paul Sérusier.

Who the Nabis were

The Nabis were a group of young painters who met as students in Paris around 1888 and called themselves *les Nabis* — the Hebrew word for “prophets.” Their founding inspiration was a tiny landscape painted by Sérusier under Gauguin's direct instruction

— a work we'll meet at the end of this tour on level five. The Nabis took Gauguin's idea — that colour could be freed from realistic description and used purely for its own emotional and decorative power — and applied it to large-scale interior decoration. They painted folding screens, room panels, stage curtains. They made painting domestic again, after the Impressionists had made it monumental.

The Pavillon Amont is where Orsay houses these large Nabi panels in a setting that approximates the kind of bourgeois Parisian interior they were originally made for. It's a quieter floor than the Impressionist gallery on level five. Most visitors rush past it on the way to Van Gogh. I'd encourage you to slow down here for a few minutes. The Nabis were the bridge between Gauguin and the early twentieth century. Matisse came out of them.

Walk back across the bridge toward the main building. We're going to look at one sculpture in particular before we move on — the original plaster of Carpeaux's *La Danse*, which was carved for the facade of the Paris Opera. Track Thirteen.

Track 13

Carpeaux's *La Danse*

Sculpture gallery · The Paris Opera facade scandal

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Locate the Carpeaux sculpture group — the original plaster of *La Danse*, showing a tall winged male figure at the centre surrounded by a ring of dancing female figures with their arms linked. It's a large group, taller than a person. You may find it in the central nave sculpture gallery or in the Pavillon Amont sculpture area depending on the current arrangement.

Walk around this sculpture group. It rewards being seen from every angle. The dancers are linked in a circle, so there is no single front.

This is *La Danse* — *The Dance* — by Jean-Baptiste Carpeaux. The version in front of you is the original plaster model, life-sized, made between 1865 and 1869. The finished stone version is set into the facade of the Palais Garnier, the Paris Opera House, twenty minutes' walk north of here. The Opera house version is in stone. This version is in plaster. Both came from Carpeaux's hands.

The Paris Opera commission

In the early 1860s, Napoleon III commissioned a new opera house to be the cultural centerpiece of Haussmann's rebuilt Paris. Charles Garnier was the architect. Garnier wanted four monumental sculpture groups on the front facade, each representing one of the performing arts: Lyric Drama, Instrumental Music, Lyric Poetry, and the Dance. He gave each commission to a different sculptor. The Dance went to Carpeaux.

Carpeaux had a problem. The three other sculptors handled their commissions in the calm, balanced, neoclassical mode the Beaux-Arts academy expected. Carpeaux refused. He wanted movement. He wanted the dance to actually look like dancing — bodies in motion, off-balance, caught mid-step, twisting around each other. He spent three years working it out. The result was a ring of seven dancing female figures circling a tall winged male genius in the centre, who holds a tambourine high above his head. The figures are linked arm to arm. They lean back, kick forward, throw their heads sideways. The whole group looks as if it could spin if you pushed it.

The 1869 scandal

The sculpture was unveiled on the Opera House facade in July 1869. The Parisian public found it scandalous, and not for the movement. For the nakedness. Carpeaux's dancing women are nude. Their bodies are visibly real — their breasts, hips, and thighs rendered with the kind of soft modelling that read, to a Second Empire audience, as more erotic than mythological. Critics wrote letters to the newspapers complaining that the women looked like "prostitutes" dancing on the facade of the city's premier cultural institution. Mothers refused to walk their daughters past the opera house. There were calls for the sculpture to be removed.

On the night of the 26th of August 1869, someone threw a bottle of ink at the sculpture. The black stain dripped down the stomach of one of the dancers and pooled at her feet. The police didn't find who did it. The stain was eventually cleaned, but the political pressure on the Opera house to remove the sculpture grew. In April 1870 Garnier commissioned a different sculptor, Charles Guméry, to make a more decorous replacement. Then the Franco-Prussian War broke out in July 1870, France lost catastrophically, Napoleon III's Second Empire collapsed in September, and the whole question of replacing the sculpture was forgotten. By the time the Opera house finally opened in 1875, the regime that had been offended was gone. Carpeaux's *Danse* stayed on the facade.

Carpeaux didn't live to see his work vindicated. He died of cancer in October 1875, three months before the opera house opening. He was forty-eight years old.

The original on the facade and the original here

The stone sculpture that's on the Palais Garnier facade today is the original carving from 1869, with the ink stain long since cleaned. But weather and air pollution slowly degraded it through the twentieth century. In 1964 it was decided that the outdoor stone original was so vulnerable that it should be replaced on the facade with a modern copy carved by Paul Belmondo, and the 1869 original moved indoors to a museum. The stone original went to the Louvre first, and then in 1986 came here to Orsay. The plaster you're standing in front of right now is the working model Carpeaux made *before* the stone — the full-scale plaster that he sculpted from clay, used to guide the stone carving, and then kept in his studio. The Orsay collection holds both: the 1869 stone original from the facade in one room, and this earlier plaster in another.

What you should take away from this room: by 1869, the academic establishment had already lost the war. Carpeaux — a state-approved sculptor, working on a state commission, on the most important state building of the Second Empire — had produced a work that the establishment found morally offensive. The line between official art and outsider art was already breaking down. The Impressionists were two exhibitions away.

Walk back through to level two and look for signs to the *MNR Gallery*, or *À qui appartiennent ces œuvres ? — Who Owns These Works?* Track Fourteen is an anchor. It's also the newest room in the entire museum. Take a quiet breath before you go in.

Track 14

The MNR Gallery — “Who Owns These Works?”

Level 2 · Opened May 5, 2026 · The reckoning room

6 min

◆ Stop & Look

Find the room on level two titled *À qui appartiennent ces œuvres ?* in French, *Who Owns These Works?* in English. It opened in May 2026 and is signposted in multiple languages. Before you go in, slow your pace. This is a different kind of gallery from anything else in the museum.

Walk in slowly. Notice that the room is quieter than the rooms around it. Notice that some of the paintings are hung so that you can see their backs. Notice the way the light is set lower.

This is the Musée d'Orsay's newest permanent gallery. It opened on the 5th of May 2026 — just days, possibly, before you walked in. It is dedicated to a category of works in the

museum's collection that have been waiting, in some cases for eighty years, for the right people to come and claim them.

What MNR means

The letters MNR stand for *Musées Nationaux Récupération* — the National Museums Recovery designation. The story is this. During the Second World War, the German occupation of France involved the systematic looting of art collections belonging to Jewish families. Roughly one hundred thousand artworks were taken from French Jews between 1940 and 1944 — paintings, drawings, sculptures, books, furniture, ritual objects. Some were taken at gunpoint. Some were sold under coercion. Some were confiscated by the Vichy regime as their owners were deported to the camps.

After the Liberation, the Allied recovery teams — the so-called Monuments Men, but also French recovery officers — found about sixty thousand of these works in Germany and Austria. Most were returned to surviving owners or their heirs. About fifteen thousand could not be returned because the original owners and their families had been killed and no heirs could be traced. Most of those were eventually sold off by the French state in the 1950s. But about two thousand two hundred were kept back for safekeeping under the MNR designation, held in trust by the French national museums until rightful heirs could be found.

Two hundred and twenty-five of those MNR works are held by this museum. Most have been in storage. This room is the first time they have been put on permanent public display — not as a temporary exhibition, but as a permanent rotating exhibition from this museum's holdings, with the explicit aim of bringing the works back into public view so that descendants of the original owners might recognise them.

What you can see right now

Twelve paintings and one sculpture are on display when this tour goes out. The selection will rotate over time as more works are brought up from storage. The works currently in the room include paintings by Renoir, Degas, Rodin, Cézanne, and Alfred Stevens.

One painting I want you to find is by Edgar Degas. The title is *Souper au bal* — *Supper at the Ball*. It's a ballroom scene from 1879, with elegant figures seated around a dinner table under chandeliers. Look at it. Now read the wall text next to it. The painting was acquired in 1919 by Fernand Ochsé, a French Jewish art collector. Ochsé was arrested by the German occupation forces with his wife Mathilde and deported to Auschwitz in 1944. They were both murdered there. Their art collection was looted. *Souper au bal* was recovered after the war. The Musée d'Orsay has held it in trust for over eighty years, waiting for an heir to come forward. None has been confirmed.

Look at another work nearby — a small Renoir titled *Madame Alphonse Daudet*, a portrait of the wife of the novelist Alphonse Daudet. Look at the painting by the Belgian artist Alfred Stevens of two children: the wall text records that it was acquired “for Hitler” — those are the exact words on the transaction record — by a German art dealer at a public auction in Paris in 1942. The original owners have not been traced.

Why the paintings are sometimes hung backwards

Some of the works in this room are hung so that you can see their reverse side. This is unusual in any museum. The reason is that the backs of these paintings carry their provenance — the trail of stamps, inventory numbers, dealer labels, transport tags, and Nazi-era markings that document the path the work took from a Jewish home into German hands and eventually back to France. The fronts are the art. The backs are the evidence. The museum is telling you, by hanging them this way, that both sides matter.

Annick Lemoine's words

The current president of the Musée d'Orsay is Annick Lemoine. When this gallery opened, she made a statement that I want to read to you, because it explains what this room is for better than I can. She said: “Behind each painting, each object, often lie shattered lives — lives disrupted, even destroyed, by the violence of the Nazi regime. Today, by dedicating a room to these works, the museum hopes both to highlight the specific issues related to them, and to convey to the public the memory of this dark period.”

Over the past thirty years, the Musée d'Orsay has returned fifteen MNR works from its holdings to identified heirs of their original owners. That is fifteen out of two hundred and forty. The other two hundred and twenty-five are still here, waiting. This room is part of the search.

Stand for a moment

Stand in this room for a moment longer than you think you need to. Read one wall text in full. Notice that the people whose paintings these were had names, addresses, professions, children. Notice that you are standing in front of objects that outlived the people who loved them. The museum is not asking you to be sad. It is asking you to know.

When you're ready, walk on into the Van Gogh suite next door. Track Fifteen is in front of his 1889 self-portrait. The two rooms speak to each other: the room you're leaving is about people whose presence has been erased; the room you're entering is about a man who put himself onto a canvas with everything he had, knowing he would not last.

Track 15

Van Gogh's *Self-Portrait*, 1889

Level 2, Van Gogh suite · *The man in the swirling blue*

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Walk into the Van Gogh suite on level two, Seine side. The room will have several Van Goghs on its walls. Find the self-portrait with the figure in a blue jacket against a swirling pale-blue background, with reddish hair and beard, looking slightly to one side. This is the 1889 Saint-Rémy self-portrait.

Look at him for a moment before you read anything. Notice that he is not looking quite at you. He is looking past your right shoulder, into the middle distance.

This is one of Vincent Van Gogh's last self-portraits, painted in September 1889. He was thirty-six years old. He had ten months left to live.

Saint-Rémy

He painted this inside the asylum of Saint-Paul-de-Mausole, in the village of Saint-Rémy-de-Provence, in the south of France. He had voluntarily admitted himself in May 1889, after a series of mental crises in Arles — the most dramatic of which was the night in December 1888 when he cut off part of his left ear and carried it to a brothel as a gift. He spent the next year in the asylum. He was allowed to paint. He was given a small studio. He produced about 150 paintings during that single year of treatment, including this self-portrait, several versions of *The Starry Night*, the wheat-field paintings, and *Irises*.

I want to be careful here, because Van Gogh has been mythologised for over a century as the tormented madman who painted with his feelings. That story is partial. He was a profoundly deliberate and technically articulate painter. He wrote nearly nine hundred letters in his lifetime, most of them to his younger brother Theo, and the letters are full of detailed analyses of colour theory, brushwork, composition, light. He read art criticism. He studied prints. He copied other painters carefully. The swirling brushstrokes you're looking at on this canvas are not the symptoms of his illness. They are a colour and movement system he had worked out over years. The illness is part of his story; it doesn't explain the paintings.

What he's wearing

Look at the jacket. A working-man's blue cotton jacket, the kind a peasant farmer or labourer wore in 19th-century France. Van Gogh wore this jacket habitually. He chose it

deliberately. Born into a Dutch middle-class family — his father was a Protestant pastor — he had spent his twenties trying out respectable careers (art dealer, school teacher, lay preacher to coal miners) and failing at all of them. By his thirties he had decided to live as a painter at the bottom of society. He dressed like the labourers he wanted to be among. The blue jacket is a statement of solidarity.

Look at his hair and beard. Reddish, close-cropped, neatly combed. He had been ill, but he was clean. He shaved that morning. The portrait is not a wreck of a man; it's a tidied-up man trying to make a careful self-record.

The technique

Look at the background. A swirling, rhythmic field of pale blue-green brushstrokes, applied in short curved dashes that move around his head in waves. Now look at the jacket: the same kind of dashes, but in a different blue. And the face: the same dashes again, in flesh tones. The whole canvas is built out of one repeated mark, in different colours and directions. It's a structural decision. Van Gogh wanted unity between the figure and the space around it — wanted them to feel like they belonged to the same material universe. He wrote to Theo about this canvas: he was trying for a portrait that was "simpler, more truthful than a photograph." Not more dramatic. More truthful.

Look at the eyes. They're slightly different colours — one more grey-green, one more blue. The asymmetry is small but it's there. Look at his mouth. Set hard, not quite a frown. Look at the line of his temple where his jacket meets his hair. The edge is a single dark stroke. He could draw.

What he was trying to do

He painted between twenty and thirty self-portraits in his ten-year career as a painter. They were partly an exercise — he was too poor to hire models, and his own face was free. They were partly a record of his own changing condition. They were also, near the end, a way of seeing whether he was still himself. After the December 1888 ear incident, he was no longer sure. He wrote to Theo: "I need above all to look at myself in the mirror, in order to paint myself, because if the figure I see in the mirror is mine, then I will be able to paint other people too." He was checking.

He gave this painting to his mother in October 1889. He sent it with a letter telling her that he was getting better, that the worst of the crisis was over, that she should look at the portrait and not worry. He killed himself ten months later, in July 1890, in a wheat field near the village of Auvers-sur-Oise, where his brother Theo had moved him to be closer to a doctor named Paul Gachet. He was thirty-seven.

Move to the next wall in the same Van Gogh suite. The *Church at Auvers* is from the last summer of his life. Track Sixteen.

Track 16

Van Gogh's *The Church at Auvers-sur-Oise*

Van Gogh suite · June 1890, one month before

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay in the Van Gogh suite. Find the painting of a stone village church with a high pointed roof, twisting walls, dark windows, and two paths in front of it that fork around the building. The sky behind is a deep cobalt blue.

Look at the church. It's a building, but it doesn't feel like a building. Notice that the walls bend slightly, as if the stone were moving.

This is *The Church at Auvers-sur-Oise*, painted by Vincent Van Gogh in June 1890. It is one of about seventy paintings he made in the last two months of his life. He had been released from the asylum at Saint-Rémy in May, moved north to be near his brother Theo in Paris, and settled in the village of Auvers-sur-Oise, about thirty kilometres northwest of the city, under the loose care of Doctor Paul Gachet. Auvers was a village of about two thousand people. The church in this painting was — and still is — the main parish church of the village, a 13th-century Gothic building called Notre-Dame d'Auvers. You can visit it today; it's a thirty-minute train ride from Paris.

What's in the painting

The church fills most of the canvas. Behind it, a deep cobalt blue sky — not a night sky, but a daytime sky painted as if it were almost solid colour. In the foreground, two paths fork around the church on either side, meeting again behind it. A single figure — a peasant woman in a white bonnet — walks along the left-hand path, small and alone.

Now look at the building itself. The walls are not straight. They tilt slightly to one side. The roof line is not quite horizontal. The pointed apse at the back leans. The Gothic windows are dark — black holes, not lit. There is no light coming from inside the church. The whole building has a kind of low pulse to it, as if you were seeing a slightly trembled photograph.

Van Gogh wrote to his sister Wilhelmina about this painting shortly after he finished it. He said the colour effect he was after was “more expressive and more sonorous in its

colour than the watercolours I did of Nuenen.” Nuenen was the village in Holland where he had painted his early peasant scenes. He was comparing this 1890 church to his much earlier work and saying: I have come a long way.

Why I want to be careful here

The standard interpretation of this painting is that the tilting walls and the dark windows show Van Gogh's mental state — that the church is buckling because Van Gogh's mind was buckling, that the dark windows show his spiritual isolation from organised religion, that the lone peasant figure represents his loneliness. Those readings are not wrong. They're also too easy.

Look at the painting technically. The walls bend because Van Gogh has used short curved brushstrokes following the contours of the building. He had been studying Japanese prints for years and had absorbed their habit of subordinating realistic perspective to expressive line. The dark windows are dark because the actual interior of a stone Gothic church at midday, seen from outside in bright sun, *is* dark — the contrast between the lit stone and the unlit interior is exactly what you see if you stand in front of Notre-Dame d'Auvers on a summer afternoon. The two forking paths are actual forking paths around the actual church. The figure of the peasant woman is the kind of figure Van Gogh added to many of his landscapes to give human scale.

So why does the painting feel charged? Because Van Gogh, by 1890, had developed a way of using colour and brushstroke that compressed an enormous amount of psychological pressure into ordinary subjects. The painting is genuinely doing what people say it's doing — it does feel like a building under spiritual strain — but it's doing it through deliberate technical means, not through unmediated emotional outpouring. Van Gogh chose every stroke.

The last summer

He had about six weeks left when he finished this painting. He wrote to his mother in early July saying he was painting daily, well, and was glad to be in the countryside. He was, by all indications, working harder than he had ever worked. He produced the portrait of Doctor Gachet, the great late wheat field paintings, the room interiors, the village landscapes. On the 27th of July 1890, he walked out into a wheat field at the edge of Auvers, shot himself in the chest with a revolver, walked back to his room at the Auberge Ravoux, and died two days later, with Theo at his bedside. He was thirty-seven. Theo died six months later. They are buried next to each other in the village cemetery of Auvers-sur-Oise. The cemetery is a ten-minute walk from the church in this painting.

Move to the next great Van Gogh in this room. The night-river scene with the gas-lamps reflected in the water. Track Seventeen is an anchor: *Starry Night Over the Rhône*.

Track 17

Van Gogh's *Starry Night Over the Rhône*

Van Gogh suite · September 1888 · The earlier starry night

6 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay in the Van Gogh suite. Find the painting of a wide dark river under a star-filled night sky, with golden lights reflected across the water and a couple walking arm-in-arm along the foreground bank. This is *Starry Night Over the Rhône*.

Look at the water for a moment before you look at anything else. The reflections of the gaslamps come down across the river toward you in long broken columns of gold.

This is *La Nuit étoilée — Starry Night Over the Rhône* — painted by Vincent Van Gogh in September 1888, on the banks of the river Rhône in the southern French town of Arles. It was the first of his great night paintings. It is not to be confused with the more famous *Starry Night* in the Museum of Modern Art in New York, which Van Gogh painted nine months later, in June 1889, inside the asylum at Saint-Rémy. This one came first. He was free, happy, productive, and looking at the actual night sky.

Where he was

Van Gogh had moved to Arles in February 1888, fleeing the cold and the grey of Paris in search of the southern light he had been reading about. He rented a small house near the railway station, in the Place Lamartine, and painted it yellow on the outside. He called it the Yellow House. It was meant to be the headquarters of an artists' community he hoped to start with Gauguin and other friends. (Gauguin would come and stay for two months in the autumn of 1888. The collaboration collapsed in the December ear-cutting crisis.)

In September 1888, before Gauguin arrived, Van Gogh painted three night paintings in quick succession. *The Café Terrace at Night* — the yellow café against a blue starry sky, currently at the Kröller-Müller Museum in the Netherlands. *The Night Café* — the green and red interior with the billiard table, now at Yale. And this one, *Starry Night Over the Rhône*, painted from the riverbank a two-minute walk from his front door.

How he painted it

There is a famous legend about how Van Gogh painted this. The legend says that he wore a straw hat with a ring of lit candles stuck around the brim, so that he could see his palette in the dark while painting outdoors. The image is wonderful. It's in every popular biography. There's a problem with it: it's almost certainly not true. The candle-hat story comes from a 1923 biography by Gustave Coquiot, published thirty-three years after Van Gogh's death. Coquiot heard the story from someone who heard it from someone. Modern Van Gogh scholars — including the team at the Van Gogh Museum in Amsterdam who control the archive of his letters — consider it folklore. A hat with burning candles around the brim would have been impractical and dangerous to wear, and Van Gogh himself never mentions it.

What Van Gogh *did* write to his brother Theo, in a letter dated September 29, 1888 — the same week he painted this canvas — was that he painted it “actually at night, under a gas lamp.” He probably started the painting outdoors on the riverbank, lit by one of the city's gas streetlamps, and finished it the next day in his studio. A local newspaper, *L'Homme de Bronze*, published a small notice on September 30th saying: “Mr Vincent, an impressionist painter, works, we are told, in the evening, by the light of the gaslamps, in one of our squares.” That's contemporary evidence. It's a gas-lamp, not a candle hat.

What he wrote about the colours

In the same letter to Theo, Van Gogh described the painting in extraordinary technical detail: “The sky is aquamarine, the water is royal blue, the ground is mauve. The town is blue and purple. The gas is yellow and the reflections are russet gold descending down to green-bronze. On the aquamarine field of the sky the Great Bear is a sparkling green and pink, whose discreet paleness contrasts with the brutal gold of the gas.”

Now look at the painting and check. The sky *is* aquamarine — a blue-green, not pure blue. The water *is* royal blue, darker than the sky. The reflections of the gaslamps in the river *are* russet-gold falling into green-bronze. He saw all of that, named all of that, and put all of that on the canvas. There is nothing imprecise about how he was working. He was making careful, observed colour decisions in a state of intense calm.

The constellation

Look at the stars. Most of them are scattered, but in the upper portion of the sky, just left of centre, you can find a small pattern that resembles the Big Dipper — the part of the constellation Ursa Major, the Great Bear, that Van Gogh specifically mentions in his letter. A modern astronomer has actually pointed out that the Big Dipper would not have been visible above the southwest horizon where Van Gogh was looking. He had to turn his head to the north to see it. He included it anyway. The constellation mattered to him — he had painted it earlier the same month in *The Café Terrace at Night*. The accuracy

he was after wasn't astronomical. It was emotional.

The couple

Now look at the bottom right of the canvas. Two figures, small, walking arm in arm along the riverbank. A man in a darker coat, a woman in a lighter dress. Van Gogh called them, in his letter to Theo, simply "two colourful figurines of lovers in the foreground." He doesn't name them. They're anyone — any two people walking a riverbank at night together under a starry sky. They're also the human reason the painting exists. The whole composition — the gaslamps, the stars, the water — is staged around their walk.

Van Gogh hoped to exhibit this painting publicly. In the summer of 1889, when he was offered the chance to send two paintings to the Salon des Indépendants in Paris, he chose this one and *Irises*. He wrote to Theo: "I don't want to exhibit anything too mad." He thought *Starry Night Over the Rhône* was the calmer of his recent works. The critic Félix Fénéon saw it and called Van Gogh "a diverting colourist even in eccentricities like his *Starry Night*." It was one of the few occasions Van Gogh was publicly noticed during his lifetime.

Walk into the adjoining Gauguin room. We're going to talk about a complicated painter and a complicated legacy. Track Eighteen is about Gauguin and the Tahiti paintings, told as honestly as I can tell it.

Track 18

Gauguin — *Arearea* and the Tahiti legacy

Adjoining Gauguin room, level 2 · The honest telling

6 min

◆ Stop & Look

Move into the adjoining Gauguin room on level two. Find the bright canvas with two seated Tahitian women in the foreground — one playing a wooden flute, one looking out at you — with a small red dog between them and a procession of figures and a carved idol in the background. This is *Arearea*.

Look at the painting first — the surface, the colours, the two seated women, the strange red dog — before I start talking. Take a minute with it.

This is *Arearea* — the Tahitian word for *Joyousness* or *Merriment* — painted by Paul Gauguin in 1892, during his first stay on the island of Tahiti. Gauguin was forty-four years old when he made it. He had been on the island for about a year.

What you see

The ground is divided into flat ribbons of saturated colour — a yellow-orange band in the foreground, a green band behind it, and pink and lavender bands beyond. Gauguin has thrown out naturalistic landscape colour. There is no attempt to make the grass look like grass. He uses the ground colour the way a stained-glass artist uses colour — as a flat decorative field, chosen for emotional intensity, not realistic resemblance.

In the foreground, two seated Tahitian women in long printed dresses. The woman on the right is playing a small wooden flute. The woman on the left looks straight out at the viewer. Between them, a small bright red dog — a real red, not a stylised redness. Behind them, in the middle distance, a procession of smaller figures dances around what appears to be a tall carved wooden idol or god-figure. Gauguin was inventing this idol — the Polynesian religious imagery he painted was largely imaginary, since the French colonial administration and Christian missionaries had suppressed traditional Tahitian religion decades before he arrived.

Who Gauguin was

Paul Gauguin was born in Paris in 1848. He spent his childhood partly in Peru, with his mother's family. As an adult he worked for years as a successful stockbroker in Paris, married a Danish woman named Mette Gad, and had five children with her. He painted on the weekends. After the 1882 stock-market crash, he lost most of his income, and in his late thirties he decided to leave his job and family and become a full-time painter.

He spent the next decade wandering — Brittany, Martinique, Provence (where he stayed with Van Gogh in Arles for two months in 1888, the disastrous collaboration that ended in Van Gogh's ear-cutting), and eventually French Polynesia. He arrived in Tahiti in June 1891, returned to France briefly in 1893, and went back to the Pacific for good in 1895, this time eventually moving to the more remote Marquesas Islands, where he died in 1903 of syphilis at the age of fifty-four.

What he was looking for, and what he found

Gauguin's public story about why he went to Tahiti was about art. He wrote that Europe had become artistically dead, that Western painting had run out of fresh material, and that he needed to find what he called a "primitive" culture untouched by Western civilisation in order to renew his work. He talked about searching for a paradise. He wrote his autobiography *Noa Noa*, in which he described his Tahitian life in romantic, mystical terms.

The reality on the ground was different. By the time Gauguin arrived in 1891, Tahiti had been a French colony for nearly fifty years. The capital, Papeete, was a colonial port with a Catholic cathedral, a French governor, French shops, and a European-dressed mixed population. Traditional Polynesian religion had been largely outlawed. The local population had been devastated by introduced diseases — from an estimated forty thousand before European contact to about six thousand when Gauguin arrived. The “primitive paradise” he claimed to find was largely a fiction he constructed for himself and for his Paris market.

The part that has to be said

I want to say this directly, because it is now part of how this painter is officially discussed at the Musée d'Orsay and at every major museum that holds Gauguin's work. Within a few weeks of arriving in Tahiti, Gauguin entered into a relationship with a Tahitian girl named Teha'amana, whom he described as his “wife.” She was thirteen years old. He was forty-three. The relationship lasted for parts of his first stay on the island. He took at least two other Polynesian girls as partners over the next decade — Pahura, also thirteen when their relationship began, and Vaeoho, fourteen. He fathered several children. He had syphilis, which he had contracted in France, and which he transmitted to multiple sexual partners.

Gauguin himself wrote about these relationships openly in letters and in *Noa Noa*. He saw nothing wrong with them. The French colonial administration in Tahiti saw nothing wrong with them. By the standards of his time and his colonial context, they were unremarkable. By the standards now applied to him by Pacific scholars, by survivors' descendants in Polynesia, and increasingly by museum curators in Europe — they were the sexual exploitation of children by a powerful European man inside a colonial structure that had stripped them of protection.

What you do with the paintings

I am not telling you not to look at *Arearea*. The painting is here, it changed the course of European art — every Post-Impressionist who followed Gauguin owes him something, Matisse most of all — and you should look at it carefully. The use of flat colour as emotional carrier rather than as description was a genuine invention. Gauguin gave painters permission to use colour the way composers use a key change.

What I'm asking you to do is hold two things at once. The first: this canvas is a genuine artistic achievement. The second: it was made by a forty-four-year-old French colonist living with a thirteen-year-old, on an island whose people had been almost annihilated by European contact, and whose religion he both suppressed and then re-invented for his market. The two seated women in the foreground are not generic figures. They are likely people he knew personally. They had names. They had lives. We mostly don't

know what they thought of him, because they didn't leave written records and he didn't ask. Recent Pacific scholarship has tried to reconstruct their voices. The work is ongoing.

Stand with the painting a moment longer. Notice the small red dog. Notice the procession in the background. Notice the Tahitian language word that Gauguin gave the painting as a title. He chose to use the local word — not a French word. That was a kind of recognition. The painting is full of these moments of partial acknowledgment, side by side with the larger fact of his presence there. Both are true at once.

When you're ready, walk to the central nave and find the escalators up to level five. Half A of this tour ends with Gauguin. Half B begins at the top of the building, behind the great clock, with the entire city of Paris spread out at your feet.

Track 19

The Great Clock Face

Level 5 · The view through the iron timepiece

4 min

◆ Stop & Look

Take the escalators or elevator up to level five — the top floor of the museum, where the Impressionist galleries are. Before you enter the Impressionist Gallery, look for the alcove behind one of the great station clocks. The clock face is a circle of glass and iron set into the wall, with Roman numerals visible from inside the building. Stand in the alcove behind the clock so you're looking out through it.

Stand here for a moment before the paintings. This is the single best view in the museum.

You're standing inside one of the original 1900 railway clocks of the Gare d'Orsay. The clock face is a circle of iron and glass, about six metres across, set into the upstream pediment of Laloux's station. The Roman numerals you can see from this side, in mirror image, are the numerals that visitors approaching the building from the Seine still read as the time. The clock still works. The gears are kept running.

What you can see through it

Look through the glass. You're facing northeast, across the Seine. On the far bank, directly opposite, are the long stone wings of the Louvre and the green of the Tuileries Garden. Beyond them, in the middle distance, the dome of the Opéra Garnier and the rooftops of the 9th arrondissement. On a clear day, on the horizon to the north, the

white domes of the Sacré-Cœur basilica crown the hill of Montmartre — the bohemian village on the edge of Paris where Renoir painted the *Bal du moulin de la Galette*, where Toulouse-Lautrec drew the Moulin Rouge dancers, where Van Gogh briefly lived with his brother Theo before he moved south to Arles.

Everything you've been looking at downstairs was made in or near the streets you can see through this glass. The Impressionist movement was a movement of one city. From this clock, you can see most of it.

Why this view matters

When Victor Laloux designed this station in the 1890s, the clocks were practical objects. Trains ran on minutes. The platforms below had to be synchronised to the second with the rest of the French rail network. The clock you're standing behind was, for forty years, an industrial instrument — a machine for telling time to travellers.

Then the trains stopped. The platforms emptied. The clock kept running, but for no one in particular. When Gae Aulenti designed the conversion in the 1980s, she made the decision to treat the clock not as a leftover but as a viewpoint. She built the alcove you're standing in. She made the clock face into a window. The decision turned an obsolete piece of railway machinery into the most photographed spot in the museum.

There's a second great clock at the other end of this floor, behind the Café Campana, where we'll end this tour. Two clocks, one at each end of the building, framing everything in between. Notice the symmetry. The whole museum is hung between these two timepieces.

Looking the other way

Now turn around. Walk into the Impressionist Gallery itself. The lights are lower than in the rooms downstairs. The walls are painted a deep grey-blue — the recent rehang chose dark wall colours specifically to make the Impressionist canvases feel as if they're generating their own light. You'll see why in the next track.

Walk into the first room of the gallery, on the Seine side, and find Camille Pissarro's *Hoarfrost* — a small canvas of a peasant carrying a bundle of firewood across a frozen field with long blue shadows. Track Twenty starts there.

Track 20

Pissarro's *Hoarfrost*

Level 5, Impressionist Gallery · The science of winter light

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

You're in the Impressionist Gallery on level five. Find the small landscape by Camille Pissarro of a single peasant figure walking across a striped frozen field, carrying a bundle on his back, with bare trees in the background and long bluish shadows across the dirt. This is *Gelée blanche — Hoarfrost*.

Look at the shadows on the field before anything else. Notice what colour they are.

This is *Gelée blanche — Hoarfrost* — painted by Camille Pissarro in 1873. It was one of the works he showed at the first Impressionist exhibition in April 1874, the show that gave the movement its name. We're going to spend most of the next hour on level five with the painters who exhibited at that 1874 show and the seven Impressionist exhibitions that followed it. Pissarro is the right one to start with. He was the only painter who exhibited in all eight.

Pissarro himself

Camille Pissarro was born in 1830 on the island of St Thomas, in what was then the Danish West Indies and is now the U.S. Virgin Islands. His father was a Sephardic Jewish merchant. Pissarro moved to Paris in 1855 to study painting, never went home, and spent the rest of his life in France. He was the oldest member of the Impressionist circle by nearly a decade, and the most generous — he was the painter who mentored Cézanne in the early 1870s, taught Gauguin to paint in the early 1880s, and quietly held the group together through years of poverty, ridicule, and infighting. Without Pissarro the Impressionists might have stayed a loose set of friends. With him, they became a movement.

What he's painting

The scene is a winter morning in the countryside near Pontoise, the town northwest of Paris where Pissarro lived. A single peasant walks across a harvested field carrying a bundle of firewood. The fields have been ploughed in long strips and left for winter. A thin frost — hoarfrost, the white feathery frost that forms overnight on cold ground — lies across the earth. The sun is low, coming from the right of the frame, casting long shadows across the strips.

What you should actually look at

Now look at the shadows. They are not grey. They are not black. They are deep blue, dark violet, soft purple. The lit strips of earth between the shadows are not white — they're a warm yellow-pink, almost the colour of cream and rust. Pissarro is doing something specific and new. He has stopped using academic shadow colour, which was

always made by adding black or umber to the local colour of the object. Instead, he's using a discovery from contemporary optics: shadows in real sunlight contain the complementary colour of the light source. Warm yellow sunlight casts cool blue shadows. He's painting what was actually there — not what the studio convention said should be there.

Look at the brushstrokes. The whole canvas is built out of thousands of short, separate, visible marks. The paint sits on the surface in distinct dabs. Pissarro is not trying to blend anything smoothly. He wants you to see, when you stand at normal viewing distance, how the eye assembles separate marks into a continuous landscape. The marks are the painting's honesty about being made of paint.

What the critics said

When this canvas was shown in the 1874 exhibition, the critic Louis Leroy wrote a famous review in the magazine *Le Charivari*. He invented a sarcastic character, a stuffy academic painter, who walks through the exhibition mocking everything he sees. In front of Pissarro's *Hoarfrost* the character cries: "Those are not shadows, those are tongue-scrapings on a dirty palette. It has neither head nor tail, neither top nor bottom, neither front nor back." The same review is the one that coined the word *impressionniste* — intended as an insult, taken up by the painters as a badge.

Pissarro lived another twenty-nine years after this painting. He went on painting, exhibiting, mentoring younger painters, and watching the movement he had helped build slowly become the most admired school in Europe. He died in 1903 at the age of seventy-three. Cézanne, who had been his student and friend for forty years, signed himself for the rest of his life as "Paul Cézanne, pupil of Pissarro."

Walk to the next major canvas in the gallery. You're looking for a field of red poppies under a summer sky, with a woman and child walking through tall grass in the foreground. Track Twenty-One is Monet's *Coquelicots*.

Track 21

Monet's *Coquelicots*

Impressionist Gallery · The first Impressionist exhibition, 1874

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay on level five in the Impressionist Gallery. Find the bright painting of a poppy field — a slope of green grass scattered with bright red poppy flowers under a pale summer sky, with a woman in a white dress and a small child in the foreground. This is Claude Monet's *Coquelicots*, sometimes called *Poppy Field near Argenteuil*.

Look at the red of the poppies. Now look more closely. The individual flowers are barely painted at all — they're short dabs of pure vermilion, almost slashed onto the surface.

This is *Les Coquelicots* — *The Poppies*, sometimes translated *Poppy Field* — painted by Claude Monet in 1873. Like the Pissarro you just left, it was shown at the first Impressionist exhibition in April 1874. The two paintings hung in the same rooms in the photographer Nadar's old studio on the Boulevard des Capucines. They are, together, the founding documents of the movement.

Where and when

Monet painted this near the town of Argenteuil, on the Seine northwest of Paris, where he lived from 1871 to 1878. These were the happiest years of his life. He had just returned from two years in England — he had fled there during the Franco-Prussian War of 1870-71 — he had a young wife, Camille Doncieux, and a small son, Jean. He was poor but he was working constantly. His dealer Paul Durand-Ruel was buying everything he produced. The countryside of the lower Seine valley, with its meadows and willows and slow-moving river, gave him the subject matter he had been looking for.

The woman and child in the foreground are Camille and Jean. They appear in many Monet paintings of these years. The second pair of figures in the background — you can just make them out, higher on the hillside, near the trees — are also Camille and Jean. Monet painted them twice, at two distances, to guide your eye through the field.

Look at the poppies

Move closer to the canvas. Look at how Monet has painted the individual flowers. Each poppy is one short stroke of red paint, or sometimes two strokes, applied wet on wet without outline. Some are larger, some almost dots. There's no drawing underneath. The flowers don't have stems. They are just red marks scattered across the green slope.

Now back up two metres. The dabs become flowers. Your eye fills in the bodies of the flowers, the stems, the slight movement in the breeze. The whole field comes alive. Monet was working from a discovery he and his friends had been testing for years: the eye builds a coherent image out of broken information faster and more vividly than the eye reads a smoothly modelled illusion. Roughness, applied with precision, makes the painting feel more alive than polish.

The 1874 exhibition

The 1874 exhibition was organised by Monet, Pissarro, Degas, Renoir, Cézanne, Berthe Morisot, Sisley, and a few others, all of them frustrated with the official Salon. They had been rejected too many times. They formed a society called the *Société anonyme des artistes peintres, sculpteurs et graveurs* — the Anonymous Society of Painters, Sculptors, and Engravers — and put on their own show without official approval. They rented the photographer Nadar's studio, hung 165 works on the walls, and opened the doors to a paying public. Thirty-five-hundred people came over the four weeks. Most of the reviews were mocking. Almost nothing sold.

But it was the start of the movement that this whole floor is built around. Eight Impressionist exhibitions followed between 1874 and 1886. Pissarro was at all eight. Monet was at four. Degas was at seven. Cassatt was at four. Manet, ironically, never showed at any of them — he kept submitting to the official Salon to the end of his life.

What happened to the painting

Monet sold *Coquelicots* to the collector Étienne Moreau-Nélaton, who gave it to the French state in 1906. It has been in this collection ever since. In June 2024, a climate activist with the group Riposte Alimentaire glued a paper poster of what the field would look like in the year 2100 over the front of the painting, and superglued her hand to the wall beside it. The painting was protected by glass and was not damaged. The activist was arrested. The protest was meant to argue that the world Monet painted is being made unliveable by climate change. The painting was on the wall again within a week.

Move further down the gallery to the canvas of a train station interior — blue and grey smoke trapped under an iron-and-glass roof, dark locomotive shapes below. Track Twenty-Two is Monet's *Gare Saint-Lazare*.

Track 22

Monet's *Gare Saint-Lazare*

Impressionist Gallery · Inside the industrial age

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay in the Impressionist Gallery. Find the painting showing the inside of a train station — an iron-and-glass triangular roof over a platform, with thick clouds of blue-grey steam rising and a dark locomotive shape coming forward through the smoke. This is Monet's *La Gare Saint-Lazare*.

Look at this painting and notice where you are. You're standing in an old train station looking at a painting of a train station. Monet painted this 1877. The Orsay opened as a station 1900. The painting is twenty-three years older than the building you're standing in. That gap is the whole nineteenth century in miniature.

This is *La Gare Saint-Lazare*, painted by Claude Monet in January 1877. It is one of twelve canvases he produced that winter, all of the same station from slightly different angles. Seven of the twelve were shown at the third Impressionist exhibition in April 1877. This was the painting that established, for everyone watching, that Monet could turn the industrial city itself — not just the countryside — into a subject for serious painting.

The Gare Saint-Lazare

The Gare Saint-Lazare was, in 1877, the busiest train station in Paris. It still is. It's the terminus for trains coming from Normandy and the western suburbs — including the line that ran out to Argenteuil, where Monet was living. He took this train constantly. He knew the station from the inside, as a daily commuter. When he decided to paint it, he had been looking at it for years.

What he did to get permission to paint it from inside is a famous story. He dressed in his best clothes, walked into the office of the director of the Western Railway, presented his card, and announced that he had decided to paint the Gare Saint-Lazare and would require the trains to be held at the platforms, the locomotives ordered to produce extra steam, and the platforms cleared of passengers during his working hours. The director, charmed by Monet's confidence, agreed to all of it. Monet worked for several weeks inside the station with the entire facility partly at his disposal.

What he was painting

Look at the canvas. The locomotive is barely there. You can see its black mass coming forward at the bottom of the painting, but Monet hasn't drawn its mechanical details. The actual subject of the painting is not the train. The subject is the atmosphere — the cloud of pale blue and white steam trapped under the iron-and-glass triangular roof, the cold winter light coming through the smoke, the colour shifts where the steam meets the sky and the sky meets the iron.

Look at the colours of the steam. Blue, grey, lavender, pale pink, almost-white. The steam is not white. The steam is everything around the steam, reflected and refracted. This is what Monet was after for his whole career: not the object, but the light at the moment it touches the object. The industrial city had made a new kind of atmosphere — a fusion of nature and machine, where coal smoke and engine steam and winter sun and glass roofs combined into something that hadn't existed in nature before. Monet was

the first painter who took it as a subject worth painting.

Why this matters here

Stand back and think about where you are. The Orsay opened in 1900 as a more advanced version of the Gare Saint-Lazare — electrified, so it didn't need the steam. Laloux looked at the kind of atmosphere Monet had painted twenty-three years earlier and decided his station would not produce it. The Orsay's trains pulled in clean and silent on electric current. The great glass roof above you was never filled with the blue-grey cloud you see in this painting. The Orsay was, in a real sense, the architectural answer to Monet's Gare Saint-Lazare — a station that wanted to be a palace, lit by daylight, not darkened by industrial smoke.

And then, eighty-six years after the Orsay opened, the building became a museum, and Monet's painting of the Saint-Lazare steam came to live here. The painting of the smoky station hangs inside the clean station. The Orsay's glass roof is over your head, and the Saint-Lazare's glass roof is on the canvas, and they were both designed by the same generation of French engineers. The frame keeps closing on itself.

Move further into the gallery. Find the wall with multiple canvases of the same building — the facade of a Gothic cathedral, painted again and again at different times of day. Track Twenty-Three is Monet's *Rouen Cathedral* series.

Track 23

Monet's *Rouen Cathedral* Series

Impressionist Gallery · The cathedral dissolving in light

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay in the Impressionist Gallery. Find a wall — or several adjacent walls — with multiple canvases of the same building: the front facade of a Gothic cathedral, all the same composition, each one in different colours: blue, gold, pink, grey, white. These are Monet's *Rouen Cathedral* paintings.

Stand back and look at the wall as a whole. The same building, painted four or five times, hung in a row. The composition is almost identical. Only the light changes.

This is the Musée d'Orsay's holding of Claude Monet's *Rouen Cathedral* series — a project he worked on between 1892 and 1894, producing thirty paintings of the west facade of Rouen Cathedral, the great Gothic church in the Norman city of Rouen. The full

series was exhibited together in Paris in May 1895, in a single exhibition of twenty canvases. Critics regarded it as one of the most ambitious painting projects of the century. The series is now scattered — in museums in Paris, Washington, Boston, Tokyo, Cologne. The Orsay holds five canvases from the series, hung together as a small reconstruction of the 1895 exhibition.

How Monet worked

In February 1892, Monet rented a room across the street from Rouen Cathedral, on the second floor of a small commercial building. The room's window looked directly at the west facade of the cathedral, about thirty metres away. He set up a row of easels along the window, with a different canvas on each. As the sun moved across the sky during the day, he switched canvases every thirty or forty minutes, working on whichever one matched the current light. When the light changed beyond the canvas he was on, he moved to the next.

He worked on this scheme for two consecutive winters, 1892 and 1893. He returned to his home studio at Giverny in the spring and continued working on the canvases from memory, refining them, repainting, building up the surface. The paint on the finished canvases is thick — in some places almost three millimetres deep — because he kept adding layers.

He suffered nightmares about the cathedral throughout the project. He wrote to his second wife Alice that he dreamed the cathedral was collapsing on top of him in colours — pink, blue, yellow — and that he woke up convinced he would never finish the paintings. He wrote: "I work with intense fatigue. Everything changes, even stone." The project nearly broke him. It also produced his most famous statement on what he was trying to do in painting: that an object has no fixed colour, no fixed form, no fixed identity. An object is only its appearance at one moment in one light, and the appearance is what painting is for.

What you can see on these canvases

Look at the surfaces. The Rouen Cathedrals on this wall are hung in the order of times of day: early morning blue light, midday white sun, afternoon gold, late afternoon orange-pink, evening violet. The cathedral facade is the same on all of them — the same Gothic portals, the same rose window, the same towers — but the stone has been almost completely dissolved by the light at every moment. In the blue morning canvas, the stone looks like underwater rock. In the gold midday canvas, the stone looks like it's melting. In the violet evening canvas, the cathedral is almost a ghost.

Walk close to one of them. From three metres back, the canvas reads as a Gothic cathedral. From thirty centimetres, it reads as a thick relief of impasto paint — ridged,

lumpy, almost sculptural. Monet painted the stone surface by giving the paint the texture of stone. The cathedral is built out of paint that has been treated like stone. The illusion only works at viewing distance. Move back and forth a few times to feel the trick happen.

What he proved

Monet had been working toward this project his whole career. The studies in his Argenteuil years, the steam paintings in 1877, the Belle-Île cliffs in the 1880s, the Haystacks in 1890-91 — all of them were rehearsals for what the Cathedrals would finally make completely clear. A subject doesn't exist outside the light that strikes it. Painting is not the representation of the world. Painting is the representation of the moment of looking. The Cathedrals showed this not as an argument but as a fact: thirty paintings of one building, no two alike, all of them true.

Walk into the central gallery space on level five. The next track is an anchor — the largest joyful painting in this museum and one of the most beloved works of art in the world. Track Twenty-Four is Renoir's *Bal du moulin de la Galette*.

Track 24

Renoir's *Bal du moulin de la Galette*

Impressionist Gallery · Sunday afternoon in Montmartre, 1876

6 min

◆ Stop & Look

Find the large painting that dominates one of the main walls of the Impressionist Gallery — a crowded outdoor dance hall scene under trees, with dozens of figures in summer Parisian dress talking, drinking, dancing, with bright circular patches of dappled sunlight falling across them. This is Auguste Renoir's *Bal du moulin de la Galette*. Stand back so you can see the whole canvas at once.

Look at the whole painting first. Don't focus on any single figure yet. Take in the warm pulse of the crowd, the trees, the dappled light, the sense of motion. This is a painting about a feeling first and a subject second.

This is *Le Bal du moulin de la Galette* — *The Dance at the Moulin de la Galette* — painted by Pierre-Auguste Renoir in 1876, shown at the third Impressionist exhibition in April 1877. It is one of the great paintings of the nineteenth century. It is also one of the few Impressionist paintings that almost everyone, including conservative critics, agreed

from the start was a triumph. Renoir had taken the visual techniques the movement had been developing — the broken brushwork, the saturated colour, the everyday subject — and produced something that was unmistakably joyful.

Where the painting is set

The Moulin de la Galette was a working-class dance hall on the hill of Montmartre, then the bohemian village on the edge of Paris. The site got its name from two old windmills (*moulins*) that had ground wheat there since the 17th century. By the 1860s, the wheat trade had collapsed and the windmills had been converted into a small entertainment business — the owner sold a thin pancake (a *galette*) and operated an open-air dance floor under the trees. Every Sunday afternoon, young working-class Parisians — seamstresses, clerks, students, shop workers, apprentice painters — walked up the hill to drink, dance, flirt, and watch the sun set over the rooftops of Paris.

Renoir was twenty-five years old, broke, sharing a studio in Montmartre, and going to the Moulin de la Galette every Sunday. He decided to make a painting of it. The technical problem was enormous. The canvas he wanted to paint was huge — over a metre and a half wide — and he wanted to paint it on location, in the open air, capturing the actual moving light. He couldn't carry a canvas that size up and down the hill every day. So he rented a small cottage near the dance hall, set up an easel in its garden, and walked the canvas back and forth on his back, with his friends helping him. He worked on it through the summer of 1876.

Who's in the painting

Almost everyone in the painting is a friend of Renoir's. The seated group in the foreground are his fellow painters and their girlfriends — the journalist Georges Rivière sits at the table with the painters Pierre Lestringuez and Norbert Goeneutte. The girls are Margot, Estelle, and Jeanne. Margot — the woman sitting at the table in the foreground in the striped blue-and-pink dress — was one of Renoir's favorite models in this period. She died young, of typhoid fever, three years after this painting was made. Renoir paid for her funeral.

The dancing couple to the left in the middle ground — the young woman in the pink dress being held by the dark-suited man — are also friends. The young woman is Margot again. The man is the Spanish painter Pedro Vidal de Solares y Cárdenas, a Cuban-born art student in Paris. The whole scene is, in a sense, a group portrait of Renoir's Montmartre circle disguised as a public dance.

The dappled light

Now look at the bright circular patches of light that fall across the dancers' clothes, the tabletops, the gravel underfoot. Look at the back of the young man in the foreground —

his jacket is covered in pale yellow and rose spots. Look at the white dress of the girl dancing in the middle ground — her skirt is moving through patches of warm yellow and cool blue. These spots of colour are the painting's technical centre. They are what dappled sunlight — sunlight filtering down through the moving leaves of the trees above the dance floor — actually looks like on cloth and skin. Renoir was the first painter who captured this effect at scale.

Conservative critics in 1877 were appalled. One critic, Albert Wolff of *Le Figaro*, wrote that Renoir had painted his figures as if they were “strewn with patches of mould.” Wolff thought the dapples looked like a skin disease. He could not accept that the optical phenomenon Renoir had captured — warm sunlight breaking on cool fabric — was a real visual experience and not a painting error. Time settled the argument. The dapples are now what people come to see.

What it captures

Stand back one more time and look at the painting as a whole. Notice how the brushwork itself moves — swirling, looping, broken — to match the rhythm of the dance. Notice how the warm yellow of the gas lamps in the upper right balances against the cool blue of the evening shadows on the left. Notice that the painting has no single focal point. Your eye is allowed to wander through the crowd the way you would actually wander through it if you were there. The composition is built to make you a participant, not a viewer.

Renoir kept the painting in his studio for two years after he made it, then sold it to his friend and patron Gustave Caillebotte. Caillebotte left his entire art collection to the French state when he died in 1894 — we're going to meet Caillebotte himself a few tracks from now, in front of one of his own paintings. The *Bal du moulin de la Galette* entered the national collections in 1894, hung at the Musée du Luxembourg, moved to the Louvre, and came here in 1986. It has not moved since.

Walk into the Degas room — there's a section of the gallery dedicated to Edgar Degas. Find the painting of young ballerinas in white tutus practising in a studio under the watchful eye of an older male instructor with a cane. Track Twenty-Five is Degas's *Ballet Class*.

Track 25

Degas's *The Ballet Class*

Degas room, level 5 · The backstage of the Paris Opéra

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

In the Degas section of the Impressionist Gallery on level five, find the painting of a ballet studio interior — a wooden-floored room with mirrors, an older male instructor in a dark suit leaning on a tall walking cane, surrounded by a group of young ballerinas in white tutus practising and resting. This is *La Classe de danse*.

Look at the dancers first. Notice that almost none of them are dancing. Most of them are resting, scratching, adjusting their costumes, leaning against a piano.

This is *La Classe de danse* — *The Ballet Class* — painted by Edgar Degas between 1871 and 1874. Degas was the great chronicler of the Paris Opéra ballet — he produced about fifteen hundred works on the subject across his career, more than half of his total output. He had a season pass to the Opéra, attended performances and rehearsals for over forty years, and knew the dancers, the choreographers, and the patrons by name. He was never interested in the glamour of the stage. He was interested in the work behind it.

Who Degas was

I want to be honest about Degas, because he was a difficult man. He was born into a wealthy banking family, was financially independent his whole life, and never had to sell his paintings to live. He was politically reactionary, deeply antisemitic, and broke with several of his closest friends — including Pissarro, who was Jewish — over the Dreyfus Affair in the late 1890s. He was misogynistic in his recorded statements. He never married and lived alone.

And he was one of the most observant and humane painters of the human body in motion that the nineteenth century produced. The contradiction is the contradiction. His work and his politics existed in the same person.

What the painting shows

The man in the dark suit leaning on the cane is Jules Perrot, a real person — a retired star dancer who became one of the great ballet masters of nineteenth-century Europe. Perrot ran the Opéra ballet school in the 1860s and 70s. Degas painted him from sittings in the studio.

The girls around Perrot are *les petits rats* — the “little rats” — the youngest students of the Opéra ballet school. They were typically between eight and fourteen years old when they began. Almost all of them came from poor working-class Parisian families. Their mothers brought them to the school in hopes of a place in the corps de ballet, which paid a salary and provided housing. The training was brutal — six days a week, twelve

hours a day, often beginning before the girls were old enough to read. Most of them failed out, or were dropped, before they reached the corps. The ones who made it spent the rest of their working lives dancing for subscribers who treated the Opéra as a marketplace.

What Degas did and didn't see

Look at how Degas has framed the composition. The viewpoint is high and off-centre, looking down into the studio from an elevated angle, like a balcony seat. The floor takes up nearly half the canvas. The dancers are crowded into the right side. There's a large empty space on the left, with a single dancer scratching her back, oblivious. The whole composition feels like a snapshot — like a glimpse caught through a doorway. Degas learned this kind of framing from Japanese woodblock prints and from contemporary photography. Both were new influences in 1870s Paris. He absorbed them faster than any other painter of his generation.

Look at the individual dancers. One adjusts her shoulder strap. One stretches her aching foot. One leans on the piano with her chin in her hands, exhausted. One scratches the small of her back. None of them look at Perrot or at the viewer. None of them are performing. Degas has caught them in the gaps between exercises — the unwatched moments when the dancer is just a young girl in a tutu, tired.

The Opéra system

The Paris Opéra of the 1870s was a complicated institution. It produced great ballet at the highest technical level. It also operated a system in which wealthy male subscribers, called *abonnés*, paid for access to backstage areas where they could approach the dancers directly. Many of the corps de ballet had patrons. Some of the patronage was respectful. Much of it was exploitative. The dancers, most of whom came from working-class families with no other income, had limited ability to refuse. Degas knew this system. He painted both the dancers and the *abonnés* repeatedly, often in the same frame. He was a witness inside it.

Now turn to the small bronze sculpture in this room — a young ballerina, fourteen years old, standing in fourth position with her chin lifted and her hands clasped behind her back. Track Twenty-Six is Degas's *Little Fourteen-Year-Old Dancer*.

Track 26

Degas's *The Little Fourteen-Year-Old Dancer*

Degas room · The scandal of mixed media, 1881

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay in the Degas section of the Impressionist Gallery. Find the small bronze sculpture of a young ballerina standing in fourth position — chin lifted, hands clasped behind her back, one foot forward, wearing a real fabric tutu. Walk around it; it rewards being seen from every angle.

Walk around her. Notice that her tutu is made of actual fabric. Notice the satin ribbon in her hair. Notice that she is not smiling and not posing for you.

This is *La Petite Danseuse de quatorze ans* — *The Little Fourteen-Year-Old Dancer* — first exhibited by Edgar Degas in April 1881 at the sixth Impressionist exhibition. The version you're looking at is a bronze cast made after Degas's death — the museum holds one of about twenty-eight casts of this sculpture, made in the early 1920s. The original, which Degas exhibited in 1881, was very different from this bronze.

What the original was made of

The original 1881 sculpture was made of pigmented beeswax over a metal armature, with real human hair on her head, a real satin ribbon, a real linen bodice, a real fabric tutu, and real ballet slippers. The wax was tinted to look like skin. The whole figure was presented inside a glass display case, like a specimen in a natural history museum. She was about two-thirds life size. She stood at eye level with the people who came to look at her.

Visitors in 1881 didn't know what they were seeing. Sculpture, by every nineteenth-century convention, was made of marble or bronze. It depicted gods, heroes, allegorical figures — the permanent and the elevated. Degas had produced something that looked like a wax-museum exhibit. Worse, he had not idealised the model. The wax girl was thin, plain-featured, with the slightly forward-jutting jaw of a working-class child. The critics were appalled.

What they said

The reviews from the 1881 show are some of the harshest in the history of sculpture criticism. One critic called her "a monkey, an Aztec." Another said she was "a flower of precocious depravity, with her face marked by the hateful promise of every vice." A third called for the sculpture to be removed from the exhibition. The objections were partly about technique — the use of wax and fabric — but they were also unmistakably about class. The critics were reading the girl's working-class face as a moral defect. They were saying the sculpture had brought a kind of person they didn't want to see

into a setting they considered sacred.

Degas was so wounded by the reception that he never publicly exhibited a sculpture again. He continued to model in wax for the next thirty-six years of his life — producing about a hundred and fifty wax sculptures of dancers, horses, and bathers — but he kept them in his studio. The whole sculpted side of his career was hidden until after his death. The bronze casts were made by his heirs from the wax originals starting in 1919.

Who she was

The model for the sculpture was a real fourteen-year-old ballet student at the Opéra named Marie van Goethem. She was Belgian by birth, lived in poverty in Montmartre with her two sisters and her mother, and was one of the *petits rats* we talked about a moment ago in front of *The Ballet Class*. She sat for Degas in his studio for the better part of 1880, in exchange for a small fee. Her family needed the money. Her mother sent both of her sisters to sit for Degas at different points as well.

What happened to Marie van Goethem after this sculpture was shown is partly documented and partly lost. Sometime in 1882 she was dismissed from the Opéra ballet school for missing too many rehearsals. After that she disappears from the official records. Her older sister, Antoinette, was arrested for theft in 1881. Her younger sister, Charlotte, became a career dancer and lived until 1945. Marie's fate is unknown. She is the most famous teenager in the history of European sculpture, and we don't know how she died, or where, or when.

What this sculpture is for

Stand close to her. Look at her face. Her eyes are half-closed — not from sleep, but from the concentration of holding fourth position. Her chin is lifted slightly, in the way that ballet teachers tell students to lift the chin. Her hands are clasped behind her back, in the way that makes the shoulders open. She is doing her job. She is fourteen. She is good at it.

Degas's sculpture is not a celebration of ballet, and it is not a denunciation of ballet. It is a witness statement. He saw her, in the rehearsal studios where most of the public didn't go, and he made a record of what she actually looked like. The hostile critics of 1881 understood, correctly, that the sculpture was indicting them — not for what they had done to Marie van Goethem personally, but for the system that they all participated in. The sculpture asked them to look at her. They refused, and they punished Degas for the request. Now, a hundred and forty years later, we can do what they couldn't. We can look at her.

Walk into the next room. Find a small intimate painting — a young woman in a dark dress sitting beside a white cradle, looking down at a sleeping infant through a sheer

netting that covers the crib. Track Twenty-Seven is Berthe Morisot's *The Cradle*.

Track 27

Berthe Morisot's *The Cradle*

Impressionist Gallery · The first Impressionist exhibition, 1874

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay on level five in the Impressionist Gallery. Find the small painting of a young woman seated in profile beside a white cradle, looking down at a sleeping baby through a sheer white netting that covers the cradle like a tent. The woman wears a dark dress; the painting is delicate and quiet. This is Berthe Morisot's *Le Berceau — The Cradle*.

Stand quietly with this painting for a moment. After the noise of the dance hall and the harshness of the dance studio, this is the first room of the museum that asks you to be still.

This is *Le Berceau — The Cradle* — painted by Berthe Morisot in 1872. It was one of nine works she showed at the first Impressionist exhibition in April 1874. She was the only woman to exhibit in that founding show, and one of the founders of the Impressionist movement — a position that almost every history book obscures.

Who Morisot was

Berthe Morisot was born in 1841 into a wealthy bourgeois Parisian family. Her sister, Edma, was also a serious painter — the two of them trained together as girls and continued working side by side into their twenties. Berthe exhibited at the official Salon for the first time in 1864, when she was twenty-three. She knew Manet, who became one of her closest friends and her sister-in-law's husband. She painted in oil and watercolour and pastel. She was, by 1870, a fully professional exhibiting painter — and the only one of her gender in the Impressionist circle.

The obstacles she worked under were ones the male Impressionists never had to think about. A woman of her class could not walk alone through working-class Paris. She could not enter cafés unaccompanied. She could not visit brothels to draw the women there, the way Degas and Lautrec did. She could not sit in the wings of the Opéra at rehearsal. She could not paint the dance halls of Montmartre or the modern leisure of the Bois de Boulogne without a male chaperone. The whole external world that the male Impressionists treated as their natural subject was, for Morisot, structurally inaccessible.

What she did instead was turn her attention to the world she did have access to: the interiors of bourgeois homes, the domestic lives of women and children, the gardens of summer houses. She painted what was around her with the same technical seriousness and the same visual intensity that the men brought to streets and railway stations and dance floors. She made the case, painting by painting, that the domestic was as worth painting as the public.

The painting

The young woman in *Le Berceau* is Morisot's older sister, Edma Pontillon. The sleeping infant is Edma's daughter Blanche, who was a few months old when this was painted. Edma had given up her own painting career to marry, which was the expected path. Berthe had decided not to. The two sisters' different choices about marriage and work were a constant subject of letters between them. The painting is partly about this: a sister looking at the sister who became a mother, and at the child who is the reason the mother stopped painting.

Look at the netting

The technical centre of the painting is the white netting draped over the cradle. Morisot has painted it with extraordinary delicacy — long pale curving strokes of cool white over a pinker underlayer, with the contour of the cradle visible underneath. The netting is transparent without being insubstantial. It catches light. It feels like fabric you could touch. The whole composition is built around this veil of white — it separates the sleeping baby from the world the way the woman's contemplation separates her from us.

Look at how Edma's left arm forms a diagonal line that mirrors the diagonal line of the netting above her. Morisot has built a geometry of two triangles — the protective tent over the baby, and the curve of the mother bending toward it. The mother and the cradle make one continuous shape, with the baby at the centre. The composition is a kind of nest.

What the painting opened

Morisot painted in this domestic register for the next twenty years, producing about four hundred works — paintings of her daughter Julie growing up, of friends visiting, of women reading and sewing and walking in gardens. She continued to exhibit in seven of the eight Impressionist shows. She was respected within the circle but largely ignored by the wider art world during her lifetime. She died of pneumonia in 1895 at the age of fifty-four — caught from her daughter Julie, whom she nursed through the same illness. Julie survived. Her death certificate, written by a clerk who did not know her, listed her profession as "without profession."

It took the better part of the twentieth century for art history to bring her fully back into view. The Musée d'Orsay now holds nine of her paintings. *The Cradle* is the one everyone comes for. It is one of the quietest masterpieces in this museum.

Walk on. The next painting is also about labour, but a different kind — three shirtless men on their hands and knees, scraping the varnish off a wooden floor in a Paris apartment, with sunlight coming in through tall windows behind them. Track Twenty-Eight is Caillebotte's *The Floor Scrapers*.

Track 28

Caillebotte's *The Floor Scrapers*

Impressionist Gallery · The labour that built modern Paris

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Stay on level five in the Impressionist Gallery. Find the horizontal painting of three shirtless men on their hands and knees on a bare wooden floor, working with hand-held scraper blades, with tall windows behind them filling the room with cool morning light. This is Gustave Caillebotte's *Les Raboteurs de parquet* — *The Floor Scrapers*.

Look at the three men working. Notice that the painting takes their labour seriously — it doesn't pity them, doesn't romanticise them, doesn't turn them into peasants. They're working urban tradesmen, and the painting treats them as that.

This is *Les Raboteurs de parquet* — *The Floor Scrapers* — painted by Gustave Caillebotte in 1875. He submitted it to the Salon of 1875. The jury rejected it. He showed it instead at the second Impressionist exhibition in April 1876, where it became one of the most discussed paintings in the show. He was twenty-seven years old.

Who Caillebotte was

Gustave Caillebotte is one of the strangest careers in the Impressionist circle. He was born in 1848 into a fabulously wealthy Parisian family — his father had made a fortune in military textiles. Gustave inherited enough money in his twenties that he never needed to work and never needed to sell a painting. He used his money for two parallel projects. He painted constantly — producing about five hundred canvases over the next twenty years. And he bought the work of his Impressionist friends, paying them when no one else would, and built a personal collection of about seventy paintings by Monet, Renoir, Pissarro, Degas, Manet, Cézanne, and Sisley.

When he died in 1894 at the age of forty-five, of a stroke while pruning roses in his garden, he left his entire collection to the French state with the condition that it be exhibited publicly. The state argued for years about whether to accept. Eventually it took thirty-eight of the paintings. Those thirty-eight paintings became the founding nucleus of the French national Impressionist collection — the works that moved from the Musée du Luxembourg to the Louvre to the Jeu de Paume to this museum. The Musée d'Orsay you are standing in, in a real sense, exists because Caillebotte made it possible. He was the patron without whom the Impressionists might have gone broke and stopped working, and he was the donor whose bequest made the public collection possible.

What he was painting

The scene is the interior of an apartment in the new Haussmann Paris of the 1870s. Three professional floor scrapers are at work refinishing a wooden parquet floor — stripping the old varnish with hand-held metal blades to prepare the wood for a new finish. This was a common urban trade in the 1870s. The Haussmann renovations had built thousands of new apartment buildings across central Paris, and the wealthy tenants who moved into them required teams of tradesmen to maintain the interiors.

The apartment in this painting was Caillebotte's own. The windows in the background look out onto the Rue de Miromesnil in the 8th arrondissement, where his family kept a townhouse. He had hired the floor scrapers to refinish a room in the house, watched them work, and decided to paint them. He paid them to keep working while he set up his easel.

What's in the painting

Look at how the scene is composed. Caillebotte stands above and behind the workers, looking down at their bare muscular backs. The wooden floorboards rush away from us in a steep exaggerated perspective — a vanishing point so aggressive that the floor seems to tilt up the back wall. The men are arranged in a diagonal line, evenly spaced. The light comes from the tall iron-railed window in the upper background, falling in long bands of cool white across the bare wood.

Look at the curled shavings of wood scattered around the men — small, intricate, painted with the same care Caillebotte gave to skin and fabric. Look at the half-empty bottle of wine on the floor in the upper left. Look at the men's thin arms and their bare feet. Caillebotte has not idealised their bodies — they are wiry, not heroic. They are working-class men doing skilled physical labour. They are completely absorbed in the work and barely aware of being painted.

What the critics couldn't see

The Salon jury rejected this painting in 1875 because they considered the subject “vulgar.” It was, by the academic categories of the time, beneath the dignity of serious painting. Floor scrapers were not biblical heroes, not Roman senators, not nymphs in a forest. They were tradesmen in an apartment. The jury could not accept that the rebuilding of Paris itself — the actual physical labour of preparing the floors that the Parisian bourgeoisie walked on — was a legitimate subject for a large oil painting.

Caillebotte’s answer was to put the painting on the wall anyway, at the Impressionist exhibition, where everyone who came in had to walk past it. The critics in 1876 mostly praised it. Even the conservative critics conceded that the technique was astonishing. Within two years, the painting was being talked about as one of the masterpieces of the new movement. By the time Caillebotte died, it was recognised as his most important work.

Walk on into the Post-Impressionist section of level five. Find the painting of two seated men at a wooden table, both in dark hats, holding playing cards, with a wine bottle between them. The figures are heavy and almost sculptural. Track Twenty-Nine is Cézanne’s *The Card Players*.

Track 29

Cézanne’s *The Card Players*

Post-Impressionist room · The architecture of looking

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Move into the Post-Impressionist section of level five. Find the painting of two men in dark hats and dark jackets seated on either side of a wooden table, each holding a hand of playing cards, with a wine bottle standing in the centre of the table between them. This is Paul Cézanne’s *Les Joueurs de cartes*.

Look at the two men first. They’re completely still. They’re not looking at each other. They’re looking down at their cards. The whole painting feels held in a long silent breath.

This is *Les Joueurs de cartes* — *The Card Players* — painted by Paul Cézanne in the early 1890s. Cézanne painted five versions of this scene over about five years, with different numbers of figures — some with three or four men, some with this stripped-down two-figure composition. The Orsay version is the smallest and the most concentrated of the five. The other four are in New York, London, the Barnes Foundation in Philadelphia,

and — famously — in the private collection of the State of Qatar, which paid more than two hundred and fifty million dollars for one of them in 2011.

Who Cézanne was

Paul Cézanne was born in 1839 in the southern French city of Aix-en-Provence, where his father was a successful banker. He moved to Paris in the 1860s to study painting, became friends with Pissarro, exhibited at the first Impressionist exhibition in 1874, and was savaged by the critics so badly that he withdrew from Paris and returned to Aix. He spent most of the rest of his life working alone in Provence, painting the landscape around his father's estate, the local labourers, still lifes of apples and oranges in his studio, and the mountain of Sainte-Victoire visible from his windows.

He was a difficult, anxious man, prone to destroying his own canvases. He worked slowly — sometimes a single still life took him six months. He had almost no public success during his lifetime. He died in 1906 at the age of sixty-seven, after collapsing while painting outdoors in a thunderstorm. He thought of himself as a failure.

Then everything changed. Within five years of his death, younger painters — Matisse, Picasso, Braque — had identified Cézanne as the most important precursor of the new century. Picasso said, repeatedly, that Cézanne was “the father of us all.” Matisse said Cézanne was “the master of us all.” Cubism is unimaginable without him. So is most of 20th-century abstract painting. The man who died thinking he had failed had in fact built the foundation for modern art.

What he was trying to do

Cézanne wrote, in a letter near the end of his life, what he thought he was trying to do. He said: “I want to make of Impressionism something solid and durable, like the art of the museums.” He admired what the Impressionists had done — the broken brushwork, the capture of fleeting light — but he thought it was unstable. He wanted to build paintings that would last the way Poussin's paintings had lasted, the way Velázquez's paintings had lasted. He wanted Impressionist perception with classical structure underneath it.

Look at how he's built this painting. The two men are essentially geometric forms — their bodies are cylinders, their hats are domes, their shoulders are wedges. The table between them is a flat plane. The wine bottle on the table stands as a vertical axis right down the middle of the canvas, splitting the composition into two near-mirror halves. The two men are not portraits of two individuals so much as two weighted masses on either side of a single architectural beam.

Look at the brushwork. The strokes are short and rectangular, applied in patches. Cézanne called these *petites sensations* — little sensations — each one a single

recorded perception of colour at a single point. He built the entire visible surface out of these patches, laid next to each other like tile. The patches don't blend. They sit beside each other. The eye, at viewing distance, assembles them into form. But the form is built out of structure, not out of smooth illusion.

What this opened

Now look at how the table tilts. The plane of the tabletop is not in correct perspective. The wine bottle stands as if it were leaning slightly to one side. The hands of the men are subtly misshapen — they don't quite resemble actual anatomy. Cézanne is deliberately distorting these elements in order to give the painting structural unity. He has decided that painterly truth matters more than optical accuracy. If the tabletop has to tilt a few degrees to make the composition balance, then the tabletop tilts.

This is the move that opens twentieth-century painting. Cézanne has given the painter permission to manipulate perspective, anatomy, and proportion in service of the painting itself — not in service of the depicted scene. Picasso and Braque took this insight and ran with it. Within fifteen years of Cézanne's death, they had broken the figure into facets and invented Cubism. Mondrian and Malevich took Cézanne's geometric impulse further and arrived at pure abstraction. All of it came out of this kind of painting — the small, obsessive, structural work that a lonely man in Aix did for thirty years without an audience.

Walk to the next room — the Post-Impressionist and Nabi section. Track Thirty pairs two small but historically enormous paintings: Seurat's *Le Cirque* and Sérusier's *Le Talisman*.

Track 30

Seurat's *Le Cirque* and Sérusier's *Le Talisman*

Post-Impressionist room · Two roads out of Impressionism

6 min

◆ Stop & Look

Move into the Post-Impressionist and Nabi section of level five. There are two paintings to find for this track. The first is large — a circus scene with an acrobat balancing on a galloping white horse, a clown leaping, and rows of spectators rising in a yellow amphitheatre behind. The second is small — about the size of a paperback book — a landscape of patches of vivid colour showing a forest and a stream. We're going to look at both.

Two paintings, two opposite roads out of Impressionism. The Seurat is large, scientific, and unfinished. The Sérusier is tiny, intuitive, and explosive. They're here together because the rest of the twentieth century branches from them.

Seurat's *Le Cirque*

First, find the large circus scene. This is *Le Cirque* — *The Circus* — by Georges Seurat. He started it in late 1890 and was still working on it when he died of a sudden illness — either diphtheria or meningitis, the diagnosis was never confirmed — on the 29th of March 1891. He was thirty-one years old. The painting is technically unfinished. Seurat had intended to add more figures and resolve the foreground, but he ran out of time.

Walk close to the canvas. Almost touch it with your nose. Look at how the paint is applied. The whole surface is built out of millions of tiny separate dots of pure colour. There are no blended areas. There is no brushwork in the traditional sense. Seurat applied each dot by tapping the brush onto the canvas. The technique is called pointillism, or sometimes — in Seurat's own preferred term — *divisionnisme*, divisionism.

He invented this technique from a careful study of nineteenth-century colour theory. He read Michel-Eugène Chevreul and Ogden Rood, two scientists who had worked out the optical principle that two adjacent dots of pure colour are mixed not on the canvas but in the viewer's eye. A dot of pure blue next to a dot of pure yellow does not look like blue and yellow at viewing distance — it looks like green, but a green more luminous than any green you could mix on a palette. Seurat decided that this optical mixing was the future of painting. He spent the last seven years of his life applying it.

Now step back five metres. The dots become forms. The acrobat is balanced on the back of a white horse. A clown leaps in front. The crowd in the amphitheatre rises behind. The colour vibrates — actually vibrates, in a way that earlier painting doesn't. Seurat had proved his theory. He would not live to develop it further. He left about seven major canvases. His early death was one of the great losses of nineteenth-century painting.

Sérusier's *Le Talisman*

Now find the small painting nearby. It is barely larger than a book — about twenty-seven by twenty-one centimetres — painted on a wooden cigar-box lid. From a distance it looks almost abstract, a patchwork of saturated colour. It shows, if you look carefully, a landscape with a stream, an autumn forest, and a small mill on the right. This is *Le Talisman* — *The Talisman* — painted by Paul Sérusier in October 1888.

The story of this tiny board is one of the founding moments of modern art. Sérusier was a twenty-four-year-old painter visiting the village of Pont-Aven in Brittany in the autumn of 1888. Paul Gauguin was also there. Gauguin had become, in his mid-forties, a kind of

guru for younger painters — he was developing his radical theory that colour did not need to describe reality but could be used purely for its emotional and decorative effect. Sérusier asked Gauguin for a lesson. Gauguin walked him out into the Bois d'Amour, a small wood outside Pont-Aven, set up a wooden board, and watched Sérusier paint.

As Sérusier started to paint the landscape in normal naturalistic colours, Gauguin interrupted him. The exact exchange has been recorded many times, with slight variations. The version most commonly told goes like this. Gauguin asked: “How do you see these trees? They are yellow? Well then, put down yellow. And that shadow, rather blue? Don't be afraid to paint it as blue as possible. And those red leaves? Use vermillion.”

Sérusier painted what Gauguin told him to paint. The result — the small board you're looking at — wasn't a representation of a forest. It was an arrangement of pure flat colour patches. Yellow path, blue shadow, red foliage, green water. The landscape was barely identifiable. Sérusier brought the small board back to Paris and showed it to a group of his fellow art students — Maurice Denis, Pierre Bonnard, Édouard Vuillard. They were astonished. They called the board *le Talisman*, the talisman, because it seemed to contain a magical principle. Around this small painting they formed the group called the Nabis — the prophets — dedicated to the principle that colour is freed from description and free to be used for its own emotional power.

What these two paintings opened

These two paintings are the two main routes out of Impressionism. Seurat took the Impressionist observation of light and made it scientific — broken into measured dots, applied by a system, derived from optical theory. That route fed into systematic modernism — the rigorous, theory-driven art of the early twentieth century. Sérusier and Gauguin took the Impressionist freedom of colour and pushed it further — dropped the observation entirely, freed colour from any reference, made painting into pure emotional structure. That route fed into Matisse, into the Fauves, into German Expressionism, into all of the colour-driven modernism that followed.

Two paintings, made within three years of each other, by two young men who knew each other through the Paris art world. Between them, they invented the next century. Seurat died at thirty-one without finishing his great circus painting. Sérusier lived another forty years and spent most of them as a quiet professor of decorative arts, painting religious subjects — he never produced another work as important as the small board he made under Gauguin's direction in one afternoon in Brittany when he was twenty-four.

We have one more track. Walk toward the far end of level five — the other end of the building from the great clock you stood behind earlier. Look for the Café Campana, with

its strange aquatic decoration and its golden light, behind the second great clock of the museum. Track Thirty-One is the closing chord.

Track 31

Café Campana — the closing chord

Level 5, behind the second great clock · The end of the tour

5 min

◆ Stop & Look

Walk to the far end of level five — the upstream end of the building, opposite the clock you stood behind at the start of Half B. Find the Café Campana, just past the exit of the Impressionist Gallery. Step inside. You'll see a strange aquatic interior — orange coral-shaped lamps, gold scale-pattern chandeliers, organic chair shapes — set against the back of the second great clock face. Find a seat or a place to stand near the clock window.

You've arrived. The end of the tour. Sit if you can. The Café Campana is one of the great pleasures of this museum, and the right place to end.

This is the Café Campana. It opened in its current form in 2011, as part of the same renovation that added the bridge to the Pavillon Amont we crossed earlier. The interior was designed by the Brazilian brothers Fernando and Humberto Campana, the two most celebrated industrial designers in South America. Their commission was to make a space that would echo the Art Nouveau decorative arts collection of the museum without imitating it — a contemporary tribute to the spirit of the 1900 Universal Exposition, in which Laloux's station had opened.

Look around

Look at the lamps. They are orange and red glass pieces shaped like coral or sea anemones, hanging in clusters from the ceiling. The wall behind the bar is panelled in hammered copper, blue methacrylate, and shimmering scale-patterned metal. The chairs are organic pebble-shapes. The whole room is meant to feel like the inside of a strange aquarium — a dream-like underwater chamber suspended at the top of an iron-and-glass train station.

The Campana brothers were drawn to the work of Émile Gallé, the great French glass artist of the 1890s whose work fills the Art Nouveau decorative arts rooms downstairs. Gallé made glass vases shaped like deep-sea creatures, glass lamps shaped like jellyfish, dragonflies, orchids, fish. The Café Campana is the Campana brothers' homage

to that tradition — a contemporary aquatic interior built on top of a 1900 station, in tribute to a 1890s glassmaker.

The second clock

And there it is, the second great clock. Look at it from inside the café. The Roman numerals are visible from this side too, in mirror image — the same iron-and-glass face as the clock at the other end of the floor, set into the downstream pediment of Laloux's station. The whole museum is hung between these two clocks. The art is the body. The clocks are the bookends.

If you came on a Thursday evening, the café is open until a quarter to nine. The lighting changes through the afternoon — the sun moves across the western sky, dropping toward the Seine, and the gold light pours through the clock face into the room. Late afternoon in this café, in late summer, is one of the great quiet pleasures in Paris.

What you've walked through

Now, before you leave, hold the whole tour in your mind for a moment. You started on the empty forecourt where the rhinoceros should have been. You stood under Laloux's glass canopy. You looked at Couture's twenty-five-foot warning to the bourgeoisie of 1847. You stood in front of Millet's gleaners and Courbet's funeral and Manet's Olympia, painted 1863, scandalous 1865. You stood in front of Whistler's mother in her arrangement of grey and black, and Toulouse-Lautrec's Jane Avril kicking on a piece of bare cardboard.

You crossed the bridge to the Pavillon Amont and met the Carpeaux Danse from the Opéra facade. You stood quietly in the MNR Gallery in front of works whose first owners were murdered in Auschwitz. You met Van Gogh in three paintings — the asylum self-portrait, the Auvers church, the Rhône under stars — and you met Gauguin with the full picture, both his radical use of colour and the children he took as partners.

You came up here, to level five, and stood behind the first great clock. You looked through it at the Louvre and the Tuileries and Montmartre, and then you turned around and walked through the Impressionist heart of the museum — Pissarro's frost, Monet's poppy field and steaming station and dissolving cathedral, Renoir's sunlit Sunday dance, Degas's ballet class and his fourteen-year-old in fourth position, Morisot's cradle, Caillebotte's floor scrapers, Cézanne's card players, and Seurat's dotted circus next to Sérusier's tiny talisman that opened the twentieth century.

Thirty-one tracks. Sixty-six years of European painting. One former train station. Two clocks. You came in through one of them. You're leaving through the other.

Where to go next

When you're ready to leave, the museum exit is back through the central nave. Walk back the way you came — down through the Post-Impressionist galleries, past the great clock, down the escalators to level zero, and out through the exit. The exit and entrance have been separated as part of the current renovation, so the exit is no longer where you came in.

If you have an extra hour and the day is bright, walk across the Seine to the Tuileries Garden. The Musée de l'Orangerie, at the western end of the garden, holds Monet's great *Water Lilies* cycle — eight enormous oval panels installed in two oval rooms shaped like the infinity symbol, designed by Monet himself in the last years of his life. The Orangerie and the Musée d'Orsay are administered together — you can buy a combined ticket. The two museums together hold the great closing chord of Monet's career: the Impressionist paintings you just walked through, and the late masterworks that grew out of them.

Goodbye

Thank you for walking the Musée d'Orsay with me. Sixty-six years of painting, two great clocks, one converted train station saved from demolition by three French presidents — the building that became the museum of the modern eye.

Zola, defending Manet in 1866, wrote that our duty is to go to the bottom of things. Every painter on these walls did that, in their own way. So, in your way, do you.

Au revoir, et merci.

